INDIANAPOLIS

NICAR26

MARCH 5-8, 2026

JW Marriott, 10 S. West St. Indianapolis, IN 46204

Join us in downtown Indianapolis for the most in-depth data journalism conference around! Explore a packed schedule with dozens of workshops, panel discussions, networking sessions and other opportunities to level up your skills.

Thursday, March 5

Welcome to NICAR! First-timers welcome and networking event 👋

8–8:45 AM • Room: White River E

Welcome to the conference! Hear from IRE staff about tips and tactics to navigate our conference like a pro. Also, you'll learn about key resources that IRE offers once you're back home.

Diana Fuentes — Investigative Reporters & Editors

How to get data out of complex documents using AI

9–10 AM • Room: White River D

Learn how newsrooms get important information out of large volumes of documents (pdfs, audio transcripts) and vet the results to power reporting.

Disha Raychaudhuri — Reuters, Duy Nguyen — The New York Times, Teresa Mondría Terol — The New York Times

Using data to investigate the global surveillance industry

9–10 AM • Room: White River E

Around the world, shadowy firms are siphoning location data from apps, telecom networks, and rogue brokers to track people with chilling precision. Whether it's journalists, Silicon Valley executives, or visitors to Jeffrey Epstein's island, no one is off-limits. This panel brings together journalists who have exposed how invisible surveillance infrastructure is being used to follow people worldwide-and how little stands in the way. The journalists will explain how they uncovered these stories, how they obtained covert datasets through techniques ranging from identifying misconfigured cloud storage buckets to scouring undocumented APIs. They'll break down how journalists can use data to expose the inner workings of the shadowy tracking systems and offer practical methods for investigating the rapidly expanding global surveillance industry.

Gabriel Geiger — Lighthouse Reports, Aaron Sankin — The Marshall Project, Andrew Couts — WIRED

State secrets: A workflow for using state-level ethics disclosure data in your reporting

9–10 AM • Room: 102

Learn how to find and use personal financial and economic interest disclosures to report on candidates and elected officials in every state. We'll demo digging into two state systems, share collaborative datasets available to participants and a comprehensive tipsheet on what data is available in each state in 2026, and run through tips on how to track changes and new filings. Reporters with basic Python skills will be able to follow along, but all attendees can benefit from the discussion of open data and workflow-building using these public documents. Participants will leave better prepared and kitted out to do strong accountability reporting on candidates and incumbents in significant elections across the country in 2026. We'll also discuss how these records can be used for deeper investigations into business connections, real estate, environmental issues and more.

Audrey Nielsen — MuckRock, Diara Townes — NC Local

Data journalism for new reporters

9–10 AM • Room: White River G

"If you build it - they will come": Many local reporters might not have the time and/or knowledge to incorporate data skills to their work. So how do you get into thinking and then doing data journalism? This session will include examples and ideas on where to start and how to work to raise awareness about data and how to use it. Over the next few days, you'll see there is a seemingly endless number of things you can learn in the data journalism world. It can be daunting! But everyone at this conference started at the same place as you. We'll help you get started! This session will cover the basics of data journalism, starting with what it is, tips for building up your skills and advice for how you can - realistically - integrate these skills into your daily reporting.

Helena Bengtsson — Gota Media / Bonnier News Local, Jennifer LaFleur — UC Berkeley School of Journalism, Cheryl Phillips — Big Local News

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R 1: Intro to R and RStudio

9–10 AM • Room: 204

Jump into data analysis with R, the powerful open-source programming language. In this class we'll cover R fundamentals and learn our way around the RStudio interface for using R. This session is good for: People with a basic understanding of data analysis who are ready to go beyond spreadsheets. Laptops will be provided.

Matt Waite — University of Nebraska

Introduction to the command line (OSX)

9–10 AM • Room: 205

Too often in data journalism we forget about the basics. And it doesn't get as basic as the command line. Even knowing a little will make your job easier. We will run through some simple commands, dive into working with spreadsheets and show you some handy tools he frequently uses at work. This session is good for: People who feel intimidated by the command line on their computer, but want to explore the power of command line tools. Laptops will be provided.

Steven Rich — The New York Times

Google Sheets 1: Getting started with spreadsheets

9–10 AM • Room: 202

In this introduction to spreadsheets, you'll begin analyzing data with Google Sheets, a simple but powerful tool. You'll learn how to enter data, navigate spreadsheets and conduct simple calculations like sum, average and median. This session is good for: Data beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Paroma Soni — POLITICO

SOLD OUT - First LLM Classifier: Practical AI in the newsroom

9 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 104

Join Ben Welsh and Andrew Briz to learn how journalists use large-language models to organize and analyze massive datasets. This three-hour, hands-on class will give you hands-on experience creating a machine-learning model that can read and categorize the text recorded in newsworthy datasets. It will teach you how to: - Submit large-language model prompts with the Python programming language - Write structured prompts that can classify text into predefined categories - Submit dozens of prompts at once as part of an automated routine - Evaluate results using a rigorous, scientific approach - Improve results by training the model with rules and examples By the end, you will understand how LLM classifiers can outperform traditional machine-learning methods with significantly less code. And you will be ready to write a classifier on your own.

Ben Welsh — Reuters, Andrew Briz — POLITICO

Following the money in college sports' new era

9–10 AM • Room: White River B

College sports have changed faster in the past five years than in the previous five decades. Join us as we break down the changes in college athletics and look at what's coming, all of which makes accurate data critical, especially financial data. We'll walk through the college finance data, explain new categories available and how to use them (and how not to). We'll also discuss how journalists can secure information about athlete name, image, and likeness deals obtained via Freedom of Information requests. Panelists will also explore current and emerging financial trends in the industry, highlighting issues that journalists across the country should be monitoring, including the $1B in severance paid to get coaches NOT to coach. We'll cover rising student fees, challenges to equity, and new athlete revenue-sharing payments. The panelists will also discuss other stories of interest in the future of college sports, including the prospect of Congressional intervention and the possibility that college athletes become employees. This panel is especially suitable for college students or anyone looking for college sports data and trying to navigate the new rules.

Jodi Upton — Syracuse University, Peyton Barish — Knight-Newhouse College Athletics Database, Michael H. LeRoy — University of Illinois

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AI tools for journalists

9–11:15 AM • Room: 201

In this session, Mike Reilley of JournalistsToolbox.ai will show you the latest and greatest AI and other free software tools for data journalists. We'll work with datasets and use AI tools to analyze and visualize them. We'll explore weaknesses, flaws and ethical issues with tools. We'll also work with a few multimedia tools as well. This session is good for beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Mike Reilley — UIC | JournalistsToolbox.ai

Excel 1: Getting started with spreadsheets (PC lab)

9–10 AM • Room: 203

In this introduction to spreadsheets, you'll begin analyzing data with Excel, a simple but powerful tool. You'll learn how to enter data, navigate spreadsheets and conduct simple calculations like sum, average and median. This class will be taught on PC computers. This session is good for: Data beginners. Laptops will be provided.

Stephen Stock — WBRZ News 2

PyCAR

9 AM–6 PM • Room: 209

This hands-on workshop will teach journalists basic programming concepts using the Python programming language. The class will introduce language basics and useful libraries in the course of a typical reporting project: scraping data from the web, analyzing a spreadsheet and visualizing the results. This session is good for beginners who want to get started with Python. Preregistration is required and seating is limited. You must bring your own laptop (no tablets) to this training.

Serdar Tumgoren — Big Local News, Rosie Cima — Big Local News, Caroline Ghisolfi — Houston Chronicle, Scott Pham — CBS News, Gerald Rich — Big Local News

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Catching the quiet changes: Automating website monitoring for investigative journalism with Visualping

9–10 AM • Room: White River I

In this session, you'll learn how to use Visualping, an AI website change detection tool, to automatically monitor and get instant alerts for important changes to any websites you need to track for your beat, whether it's local court dockets, government agency websites, a politician's social media pages, or something else. We'll walk through setting up a Visualping alert, using different features and settings, and tips for using Visualping's AI criteria and summary features. Attendees are welcome to sign up for a free Visualping account at visualping.io to follow along.

Kayla Zhu — Visualping

From delving into data to door knocking: Finding people behind the numbers and getting them to speak

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River D

You've finished your FOIAs. You've done the data analysis. You've talked with experts. Now you're ready to put your story together. There's just one problem. You haven't yet spoken to the people who are impacted by the findings found in your research. In this panel, journalists from across the media landscape talk about ways they've found people who are impacted by the topics they were covering and/or data they were researching. Plus, once you've found the people, how do you convince them to go on the record? The panelists are here to answer your questions and talk about how they centered their stories around the people they found.

Jared Kofsky — ABC News, Stephanie Lamm — Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Caresse Jackman — InvestigateTV, Elisabeth Gawthrop — American Public Media, Mark Nichols — ABC News

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How to investigate Telegram

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River G

A session that shows participants a variety of tools and tricks for investigating Telegram chats and channels. Telegram is a primary source for a lot of newsworthy activity: militias in armed conflicts around the world, neo-Nazi terror organizations, illicit markets, etc. Telegram also has a very open and accessible API, which makes fetching and working with their data easier than many other social media platforms. But there's a lot of features of and knowledge about Telegram that often isn't always apparent, which can cause pitfalls for journalists and researchers who aren't familiar with it.

Tristan Lee — Decoherence Media, Jennefer Harper — Decoherence Media

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Reporting on maternal and infant health in turbulent times

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River E

The U.S. has the highest maternal mortality rate of any high-income nation, with stark differences within the U.S. along racial and geographic lines. Early evidence suggests that system shocks like Covid and state-level abortion bans may have made pregnancy and childbirth even more dangerous. Meanwhile, the Trump administration has slashed public health initiatives, altered childhood vaccine schedules and gutted many federal data collection projects, including those focusing on maternal and infant health outcomes. This panel will explore the ways we can use available data to report on maternal and infant health, and discuss ways we can continue this work at the state, regional and national level despite the loss of some federal data sources.

Andrea Suozzo — ProPublica, Sophie Chou — Independent journalist, Holly Hacker — KFF Health News

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R 2: Data analysis and plotting

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 204

We'll use the tidyverse packages dplyr and ggplot2, learning how to sort, filter, group, summarize, join, and visualize to identify trends in your data. If you want to combine SQL-like analysis and charting in a single pipeline, this session is for you. This session is good for: People who have worked with data operations in SQL or Excel and would like to do the same in R and have some experience working with RStudio. Laptops will be provided.

Adriana Rezal — Houston Chronicle

Cleaning data with OpenRefine

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 205

Learn how to explore, clean and reshape data using OpenRefine, a versatile tool that great for data novices and power users alike. This session is good for people with some basic experience working with data. Laptops will be provided.

Christian McDonald — University of Texas at Austin

Google Sheets 2: Formulas & sorting

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 202

Much of Google Sheets' power comes in the form of formulas. In this class, you'll learn how to use them to analyze data with the eye of a journalist. Yes, math will be involved, but it's totally worth it! This class will show you how calculations like change, percent change, rates and ratios can beef up your reporting. This session is good for: Anyone who has taken Google Sheets 1 or has been introduced to spreadsheets. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Gavin Off — University of Florida

Finding the story: Education data

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 102

The issues we cover in education reporting are wide-ranging - from who manages our education institutions, to how students perform, to how colleges are funded. Let's go over some ways to set yourself up for success as an education data reporter by learning about helpful datasets, how to request and organize information, and how to avoid common pitfalls when working on an education team. This session is good for anyone! You must bring your own laptop (no tablets) to participate.

Chris Mullin — Lumina Foundation

Excel 2: Formulas & sorting (PC lab)

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 203

Much of Excel's power comes in the form of formulas. In this class, you'll learn how to use them to analyze data with the eye of a journalist. Yes, math will be involved, but it's totally worth it! This class will show you how calculations like change, percent change, rates and ratios can beef up your reporting. This class will be taught on PC computers. This session is good for: Anyone who is comfortable navigating Excel. Laptops will be provided.

sandra fish — QuizTheVote

Accessing records to report on immigration enforcement actions

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River I

Data sets and public records offer critical context for coverage of immigration enforcement actions taking place in communities across the country, but it's often difficult to know where to look for this information or how to respond when access is denied. This session will provide practical tips for journalists on how to obtain data and records for reporting on immigration issues, and the resources available to push for greater transparency when necessary.

Gunita Singh — Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press (RCFP), Will Craft — The Guardian, Eileen Grench — Documented, Jim Daley — South Side Weekly, Pratheek Rebala — ProPublica

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The SLAPP Back Initiative: Building a first-of-its-kind database

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River B

The SLAPP Back Initiative: Building a first-of-its-kind database Have you considered building a database of your own but are not sure where to start? Join lead researcher Susanna Granieri of The SLAPP Back Initiative, a first-of-its-kind database tracking strategic lawsuits against public participation, meritless and frivolous actions used to chill speech and deter scrutiny. In this demo session, Susanna will outline the team's steps from inception to launch: What research tools were used? How was the methodology developed? How did they interrogate the data and bulletproof their findings? What questions have they answered, and what questions remain? She'll also show you how, as the database grows, it can help empower your journalism, identifying common offenders and frequent targets in your state.

Using data to find sources

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River D

Data can provide context, show trends, and debunk false claims. But journalists don't always recognize its power to elevate even the more traditional parts of reporting. Data analysis can help you find human sources (often with names and contact information in the spreadsheet itself). It can also help you pinpoint where to go for field reporting. We'll explore all these possibilities in this panel with a handful of examples you can take back to your newsroom.

Brian Whitton — The Wall Street Journal, Aaron Mendelson — The Trace, Adriana Navarro — Arizona Center for Investigative Reporting, Taylor Nichols — Houston Chronicle

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Coaching ChatGPT to help with coding and data tasks

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 102

ChatGPT, widely misunderstood and in some cases misused, can be a powerful tool to improve efficiency in our day-to-day work. Give ChatGPT a few rows of publicly available data and ask it to write a data dictionary. We'll use ChatGPT to help write a public records request for us, have it help us make sense of data and we'll even use it to write a Python script to reshape unruly Excel data. The best part? You don't need to know Python to write this code. This session is good for everyone. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets).

Charles Minshew — Atlanta Journal-Constitution

Introducing libfec, a faster FEC filing parser

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 205

A new election cycle means a brand new open source tool for parsing the Federal Election Commission's custom .fec file format! This year `libfec` has been released, a new toolkit that parses FEC files even faster than pre-existing tools, and uses the FEC's API to find the filings for the exact candidate, election, or PAC that you care about. This class will go over how to use libfec in a midterm election year - finding all individual donors for all candidates in a House or Senate race, seeing where campaigns spend their money, and tracking down Super PACs that fuel outside spending in a newsroom's district. Along the way participants will learn how to use libfec to source all this data, including how to export data into CSV, SQLite, or JSON for further analysis or data visualizations. Participants should have a basic knowledge of using the command line. Laptops will be provided.

Alex Garcia — Datasette

Investigating the AI data center boom

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River I

This panel will discuss how to investigate the environmental and social impacts of new data centers being built in the US. Panelists will present strategies for revealing hidden costs of the data center boom, exploring how data centers strain resources and reshape rural communities, particularly in drought-stricken and farming regions.

Michelle Ma — Bloomberg, Claire Keenan-Kurgan — Interlochen Public Radio, Matt Topic — Loevy + Loevy, Phoebe Liu — Forbes

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R 3: Gathering and cleaning data

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 204

Learn how to import a wide variety of files in R including spreadsheets, files on the web and HTML tables, and transform the results into usable data. This session will also focus on how to clean and structure the data you've gathered in preparation for analysis using tidyverse packages. This session is good for: People who have some experience using R and the Tidyverse. Laptops will be provided.

Sean Mussenden — University of Maryland

Google Sheets 3: Filtering & pivot tables

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 202

A look at the awesome power of pivot - and how to use it to analyze your dataset in minutes rather than hours. We'll work up to using a pivot table by first sorting and filtering a dataset, learning how to find story ideas along the way. This session is good for: Anyone familiar with formulas, sorting and filtering in a spreadsheet program. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Aaron Mondry — Outlier Media

Journalism jobs for Internationals

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River E

Things are tough right now for international journalists and students who want to work in the US and need visas. We face challenges finding newsrooms willing to hire or sponsor us, navigating the visa landscape and helping our employers understand the process. It's time for us to band together. Journalism Jobs for Internationals was created by volunteers to share resources that address those challenges facing international journalists and build a community where one supports another. In this session, we will present the information we compiled, answer any questions and listen to your feedbacks. Help us better help you!

Jasmine Han — Informa TechTarget (Industry Dive)

Networking: Students

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River B

Mix and mingle, meet friends old and new, and build your professional community in this fun and informal networking session. This session is for journalism students.

Cam Rodriguez — Independent journalist

Excel 3: Filtering & pivot tables (PC lab)

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 203

A look at the awesome power of pivot - and how to use it to analyze your dataset in minutes rather than hours. We'll work up to using a pivot table by first sorting and filtering a dataset, learning how to find story ideas along the way. This class will be taught on PC computers. This session is good for: Anyone familiar with formulas, sorting and filtering in Excel or another spreadsheet program. Laptops will be provided.

Emily Hopkins — Mirror Indy

From good to great data viz design

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 201

Learn design tips for polishing your graphics to tell clear and compelling stories. This session will involve participatory discussion where we review example charts and maps as a group, covering design challenges like focusing the user's attention, making complex data understandable, and using non-standard chart types. This session is good for: People who create graphics and are interested in learning how to improve their design. Laptops will be provided.

Will Merrow — Council on Foreign Relations

Finding a needle in a haystack: How to manage document-heavy investigations

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River G

Searching for relevant evidence for a story through a never-ending pile of documents, legal forms, contracts, emails, videos, or cell phone data can be taxing and time-consuming, even for the best investigative teams out there. The team at Everlaw will demonstrate their tools to help with automatic transcription of audio and video (think bodycam footage, depositions, interview recordings), making documents text-searchable through optical character recognition, file management tools (like search, labeling, AI summaries), analysis tools (like data viz and topic clustering), and story-building tools (drafting, citations, and AI writing assistance). They'll show how newsrooms like the San Francisco Chronicle, ProPublica and Fast Company uncover key information using their tool. You'll also learn about Everlaw's free offering for journalists, which includes unlimited users, training and support at no extra cost.

Lunch bunch

12:30–2:15 PM • Room: TBD

Make some new friends over lunch! Show up and we'll connect you with other folks who want to chat and network over the lunch break -- a great way to make a big conference feel smaller. Meet at the bottom of the escalators on Level 1.

Everyone can be (and should be) a housing reporter

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River G

The housing crisis is touching communities of every size - not just coastal cities or low-income renters. In this session, we'll walk through practical data tools, sources, and reporting techniques to cover affordable housing challenges, evictions, and homelessness. Whether you're new to the beat, jumping on a fast-moving daily story, or looking to deepen your expertise, you'll learn accessible methods for finding, analyzing, and localizing housing data to produce clearer, more impactful reporting.

Juan Pablo Garnham — Eviction Lab, Aaron Mondry — Outlier Media

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AI concepts you should know

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River D

AI, Machine Learning, Deep Learning ... what do these terms really mean, and what is the difference? Many journalists are still grappling with an explosion of buzzwords and concepts. This session aims to demystify the jargon and provide a clear, practical explanation of key AI terms and tools.

Libby Seline — University of Chicago, Ryan Serpico — Hearst, Jon Keegan — Sherwood News

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How to scrape and analyze sports data in R to tell stories that stand out

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 104

There's a lot of publicly available sports data. How can you use those sources to build new datasets and tell compelling stories about what's happening off the field? Learn how to quantify trends and debunk myths by leveling up your ability to scrape popular sports data websites, then analyze that data in creative ways. Attendees will come away from this hands-on session with experience scraping and analyzing data from the website Sports Reference, which maintains data for all the major sports, plus a better understanding of basic web-scraping concepts. Attendees should have some familiarity with R and RStudio. Laptops will be provided.

Matt Waite — University of Nebraska

Enhancing public records work with LLMs

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 202

Explore the Python libraries for the MuckRock Requests and DocumentCloud APIs and how they can be used with large language models (LLMs) to streamline records requests assist in analyzing responsive documents. Participants will also be introduced to llm-documentcloud, a plugin for LLM command-line tool/Python library that enables feeding documents for analysis in various LLMs for analysis. The session will cover strategies for crafting clearer, more effective public records requests, as well as techniques for summarizing, organizing, and extracting data and insights from responsive documents. Attendees are encouraged to bring their own projects, ideas, and questions for exploration. This session is good for those with some Python experience. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Sanjin Ibrahimovic — MuckRock, Allan Lasser — MuckRock

Introduction to network visualization and analysis

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 201

A hands-on walkthrough of an entire network visualization workflow. Starting with processing the data, converting it into a network format, laying it out in Gephi, and visualizing it using one of several visualization libraries (Holoviews, Sigma.js, Cosmograph, etc). While discussing different choices throughout the process (aggregation, layout algorithm, filtering, etc.) and their impact on the visualization. This session is good for those with experience working with data and visualization libraries. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Tristan Lee — Decoherence Media, Jennefer Harper — Decoherence Media

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Finding the story in higher education data

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 102

From campus speech policies to federal funding cuts, higher education is in the headlines now more than ever. As former reporting interns for The Chronicle of Higher Education, we'll lead a lightning round on data sources we used to cover some of the hottest stories in higher ed: from the fall of affirmative action to a state-mandated purge of general education courses. This session is ideal for student journalists, and useful for any reporter covering the education beat. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Declan Bradley — Oberlin College, Garrett Shanley — Miami Herald

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Next-gen crime data: Know your NIBRS!

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River I

Forget murder, robbery and burglary. Do you know how many ATM thefts your local police logged last year? Or carjackings? Or stalking cases? Most police agencies now log a wealth of detail on 58 crimes via the National Incident-Based Reporting. Learn how to get started using this invaluable but complicated data.

Paul Overberg — The Wall Street Journal, Jill Castellano — The Marshall Project, Maia Rosenfeld — KFF Health News

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Detangling federal lobbying disclosures with LobbyR

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 204

Political influence is getting harder and harder to track, but the Lobbying Disclosure Act Reports helps cut through some of the noise. With LobbyR, researchers, journalists, and others can easily access, clean, and visualize a much more comprehensive version of federal lobbying disclosures to understand what companies, groups and other interests are asking Congress and the administration for. In this session, you'll learn how just a few lines of R code will allow you to query, summarize, and plot real-world lobbying transparency data, enabling rapid insights and automated workflows. And there's no complex setup required. If you want to ask questions like "who lobbied on issue X in the last five years?", or "how many dollars did registrant Y report?", or "are there clients/registrants filing that overlap?", LobbyR makes this work programmatic, reproducible, and transparent. Participants should have a basic knowledge of R. Laptops will be provided. Participants should pre-register for an API key through this link: https://lda.gov/api/register/

Chris Cioffi — Bloomberg

Introducing the new IRE Resource Center

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River E

The new IRE Resource Center is here! Members can now access an enhanced, user-friendly search interface with more opportunities to easily surface thousands of tipsheets, contest entries and other training materials. In this session, the volunteers who built the app will demonstrate its new features, talk about how it was made and solicit live feedback from the audience.

Ben Welsh — Reuters, Derek Willis — University of Maryland

The two essential data sources for covering government spending

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 203

Tracking government spending has never been more convoluted. In the last year, DOGE took a "chainsaw" to federal contracts and grants, entire departments canceled awards en masse, and award recipients lost faith in the federal government as a financial partner. In the midst of it all, reporters do have public tools to dig through what some might see as a trail of chaos. In this session, we will break down two specific data resources any reporter needs to follow federal money: USA Spending and Sam.gov. Whether reporters are interested in funds from a specific federal department, funds going to a specific county, or even funds meant to achieve a specific purpose, this session will cover what is knowable, how to know it, and how to fact-check it. Panelists will also walk through what is not knowable and what should always be confirmed with federal agencies before going to print. This session is good for all levels of experience. Laptops will be provided.

Jessie Blaeser — POLITICO, Lucia Walinchus — NBC Owned Television Stations, Rosie Cima — Big Local News

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Fun with shapes: Scripted mapping in R or Python

2:30–6 PM • Room: 205

Let's face it, QGIS is the Excel of geospatial analysis. Sure, doing simple mapping in it and ArcGIS is a blast, but executing complex, reproducible joins and measurements can be a real drag. Taking a more scripted approach is way less of a buzzkill, especially when you need to revisit your earlier work or share with others. Whether you choose R or Python, follow along from mapping basics to more complex techniques that will make your next geospatial analysis a walk in the park. Cut loose, write some replicable code and have fun with shapes! Preregistration is required and seating is limited. To get the most out of this session, you should have a working knowledge of both GIS/mapping techniques and some experience with either Python or R. Laptops will be provided.

Allie Kanik — Houston Chronicle, Cam Rodriguez — Independent journalist, Ryan Little — ProPublica

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Supporting the next generation of journalists through a historic slide in U.S. press freedom

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River B

As the next generation of journalists enters the field at a time when the Committee to Protect Journalists has warned that "press freedom in the United States is under siege," we explore how student reporters are navigating that threatening climate on and off campus. We hear from student journalists whose universities have encroached on editorial independence or withdrawn institutional support. We also hear from a student journalist who was arrested and convicted for doing his job. As the industry reckons with this reality on a broad scale, we speak with a senior reporter at the U.S. Press Freedom Tracker and invite all in attendance to join us in a conversation as we ask: How can we best support our student colleagues under such conditions?

Andrew Miller — Indiana Daily Student, Mia Hilkowitz — Indiana University, Lucas Griffith — University of Cincinnati, Olivia Mapes — The Purdue Exponent, Stephanie Sugars — U.S. Press Freedom Tracker, Elaine Monaghan — Indiana University

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Pitch, please! How to contribute to the IRE Journal

2:30–6 PM • Room: Foyer

Do you have a cool data project you want to highlight? Some FOIA expertise you wanna share? How about some *thoughts* about the industry? Pitch IRE Journal managing editor Adam Rhodes in the exhibitor hall!

Adam Rhodes — IRE & NICAR

Wanna get hired? Tales from the trenches

3:45–6 PM • Room: 102

We're the hiring managers who've seen it all: the 11-page resumes, the glamorized headshots in applicant packages, the ones that come with a reference letter from Mom. We also know what we're looking for when we get your materials, and we're ready to spill out secrets. Come ask us anything, about resumes, cover letters, interviewing, etc. Participants should walk away with an actionable tipsheet of ideas and ways to improve their job searching techniques and give their materials a boost.

Emma Carew Grovum — Kimbap Media, Kai Teoh — The Dallas Morning News

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Challenges with cross-domain collaboration

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River B

As newsrooms shrink more journalists are collaborating with academics, nonprofit organizations and other groups for investigations. While collaborating allows us to do work we couldn't otherwise, they also come with specific challenges. What do you do when stakeholders want different things? Or when one team isn't able to deliver what was promised?

Lisa Pickoff-White — California Reporting Project, Emily Kennedy — Centre for Anthropology and Journalism, Soo Oh — CalMatters / The Markup, Sam Stecklow — Invisible Institute

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Data in the world of audio

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River D

Are you a data-oriented reporter working at a public radio station? Interested in presenting findings from a data-driven investigation on a podcast or talk show? This session will debunk the common saying heard in many public radio newsrooms that "numbers and radio don't mix." This panel will provide practical tips on how to effectively present data-driven reporting in different audio mediums, ranging from long-form podcasts to short-form newscasts. It'll also be a open forum for discussing how reporters have found creative ways to put data journalism on air.

Hannah Reale — GBH News, Clayton Guse — WNYC/Gothamist, Amy Qin — WBEZ

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10 things you didn't know you could do in R

3:45–6 PM • Room: 204

R is great for quick data exploration, visualization and spatial analysis. But did you know you can extract text from images, send customized emails and chat with PDFs all without ever leaving the cozy comfort of R? In this session, we'll zip through a few lesser-known or relatively new R packages for working with large language models, media and databases. Though pitched at intermediate users interested in getting more mileage out of R, this demo will also give beginners a taste of what's possible. As a bonus, we'll invite attendees to complete a short survey sharing some of the unexpected ways they use R in their newsrooms and circulate the results in a tip sheet after the session. This session is good for people with some experience working with R. Laptops will be provided.

Amy DiPierro — EdSource

From chaos to narrative: Using R for story discovery in document collections

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 203

This session will introduce journalists to using R to ingest large numbers of lawsuits, transcripts, news articles and similar material and to discover story leads through content analysis methods. Journalists will learn the benefits and drawbacks of sentiment analysis, keyword in context text retrievals, language dependency parsing, and extraction of top two- and three-word phrases. These tools in R's tidytext package can help reporters discover themes and tips in large groups of documents that otherwise could do undetected. This session is good for those with some experience using R. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Rob Wells — University of Maryland

React 101: Demystifying arrays, state values and components

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 202

Do you use React to create interactives, or are you interested in solidifying your knowledge of component-based javascript libraries? Join this hands-on session to nail down the basics of mapping, filtering, state values, useEffects and other confounding concepts. This session is good for those with some experience using JavaScript. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Carson TerBush — The Washington Post, Aadit Tambe — The Washington Post

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Accessing data on deaths in custody

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River E

Thanks to recent FOIA lawsuits and the efforts of organizations like The Marshall Project, The Data Liberation Project, Behind Bars Data Project, and Mapping Police Violence, data on deaths in custody is more accessible than ever. This panel will guide reporters on how to find and use this data to investigate deaths in prisons, jails, and police custody. Attendees will learn about what data is available, what's missing from the data, and how the data can reveal problematic patterns in trends in the local law enforcement agencies.

Ethan Corey — Behind Bars Data Project, A.J. Lagoe — KARE-TV, Ivy Scott — The Marshall Project

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Running large language models locally, on your computer!

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 104

Learn how to run powerful language models like Llama, Mistral, and Gemma directly on your own computer. This hands-on session covers the basics of local LLM deployment using LM Studio, hardware requirements (spoiler: you don't need a supercomputer), and practical reporting applications. We'll discuss the trade-offs between local and cloud-based models, explore use cases where local models excel, and demonstrate workflows for integrating LLMs into your reporting toolkit. This session is good for beginners and anyone who wants to learn to run LLMs locally. Laptops will be provided.

Aarushi Sahejpal — American University, Dhrumil Mehta — Tow Center at Columbia University

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Finding the story: Using DNS search for investigative journalism

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 201

Every online interaction begins with a lookup in the Domain Name System (DNS), the backbone of the Internet. As a result, there are digital footprints left behind in the DNS. With the demise of Whois, investigative reporters are looking for new tools to uncover these footprints. Learn how to use DNSDB Scout, a tool to query DNSDB, a historical passive DNS database, to discover previously unknown online connections and gain new information to advance your ongoing and breaking news investigations. Basic knowledge of the Domain Name System (DNS) is helpful, but not required. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Daniel Schwalbe — DomainTools

Networking for LGBTQ+ journalists

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River I

Mix and mingle, meet friends old and new, and build your professional community in this fun and informal networking session. This session is for anyone who identifies as part of the LGBTQIA+ community or as an ally.

Laura Moscoso — Investigative Reporters & Editors, Adam Rhodes — IRE & NICAR

How to turn local data into far more useful tools for your newsroom - and your audiences

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River G

Local data like election results, campaign finance, and school budgets can become core infrastructure for your newsroom, helping reporters add context and depth to their stories that no one else will have. And while they support your editorial department, those same data tools can also help your newsroom launch useful and engaging news products. Learn about two such projects underway in Lancaster County, Pa. and at The Texas Tribune and see how they are designing and building core data infrastructure to support stronger local government coverage.

AmyJo Brown — War Streets Media, Rob Reid — The Texas Tribune

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Data investigation frameworks: How to think big picture about what your data will prove

5–6 PM • Room: White River I

In investigative journalism, data often provides the core evidence to hold powerful actors accountable - proving wrongdoing, harm or scale. But how can you know what data tools and skills you'll need when you start an investigation? This session will break down the basic structure of a data investigation, outlining a few frameworks for how data provides that proof. We won't focus on specific tools - the best tool for the job will be different for every story. Instead, we'll practice how to think about using data to strengthen an investigation, so that you know exactly what questions you want data to answer before you spend time finding and analyzing it. This session will include audience participation and is well-suited to early career journalists or anyone seeking to get more comfortable with thinking and planning for data-based investigative reporting.

Adiel Kaplan — Tow-Knight Center for Journalism Futures

Analyzing election data with Polars and Python

5–6 PM • Room: 104

Polars is a modern dataframe library for Python that's fast, focussed, and easy to use. At the Financial Times, Polars has been an essential component in our live election results pipelines and our computational investigations. Polars has many advantages over the older pandas dataframe library, including speed and type safety. But perhaps the biggest benefit is that it has a simple, logical, and memorable API that makes it much more enjoyable to use. Working with tabular data in Polars feels as easy and expressive as it does with R's tidyverse. In this session we will use election results data to teach the fundamentals of analysing tabular data with Polars, including: • Loading and saving data • Selecting columns • Filtering rows • Sorting dataframes • Creating new columns by combining and calculating values from existing columns • Grouping rows and aggregating their data • Using joins to combine two or more dataframes We will teach these skills through examples of how we have used the library in original data journalism work. This session is good for people with Python experience. Laptops will be provided.

Eade Hemingway — Financial Times, Oliver Hawkins — Financial Times

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AI agents and pipelines with no-code tools

5–6 PM • Room: 202

Want an automatic digest of news on your beat or what your city council has been up to? Get pinged on Slack with a summary when an editor takes a pass at your story? All without touching a line of code? In this session we'll learn to use no-code AI pipeline tools like n8n and ActivePieces to automate journalistic processes. Learn what agents and pipelines are, what they do, and the bevy of vocabulary and technical terms you'll need to put your own workflows to... work! - What APIs are and how they can supercharge your workflow - Schedule monthly, weekly, or hourly automatic processes - How to set up and use webhooks to trigger actions - Differences between providers and models - Unraveling technical settings like temperature and structured output Participants will learn the fundamental basics of how no-code AI pipeline tools work and integrate with other services, and will be well-prepared to start exploring on their own. This session is good for people with some experience working with data. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Jonathan Soma — Columbia University

Free or cheap web-scraping tools - no coding required!

5–6 PM • Room: 201

In this demo, we will go over a range of free or cheap scraping tools that reporters can use to scrape websites without programming. Some of those include Chrome extensions- Instant Data Scraper and WebScraper- as well as scraping with Google sheets. This session is good for beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this demo class.

Alexandra Glorioso — Miami Herald, Aïcha Camara — McClatchy

Finding and using undocumented APIs

5–6 PM • Room: 203

This tutorial will introduce reporters to an exciting and often overlooked data source found on every website. You will learn how to find and use hidden APIs as a reporting resource, and hear about how this data source has been used in past reporting. We'll be working off this scripted documented: https://inspectelement.org/apis This session is for reporters who want to diversify their data sources. You don't need to write code: we'll teach participants to find hidden APIs in your web browser, but knowing some coding will let you to unlock detailed and rich datasets hidden in plain sight. Laptops will be provided.

Piotr Sapiezynski — Northeastern University

Monitoring police accountability laws across the U.S.

5–6 PM • Room: White River B

Led by California and New York, states across the U.S. have begun adopting laws to give the public access to police accountability data, including use-of-force and discipline records. But what's available varies by state, and there are no central repositories for tracking problem police officers (and some agencies fail to access what is available). In addition, laws that are intended to make sure problem police never work in law enforcement again are riddled with inconsistent application. This panel will take a deeper look at the documents and data across the country, and the stories reporters have done in multiple states to illuminate what has previously been shielded from the public. We dig into how we went about forming news/university/private partnerships to report on unevenly enforced police discipline, and how you could execute a similar project with the data and documents in your state. This panel was planned in conjunction with "Utilizing new police misconduct and employment databases," scheduled for Friday at 9:00 a.m. This panel will focus on changing laws, data partnerships and developing stories; the next panel will give specific how-tos using available data.

Jodi Upton — Syracuse University, Sam Stecklow — Invisible Institute, Sarah Taddeo — USA TODAY Network, David Robinson — Rochester Democrat and Chronicle, Katey Rusch — UC Berkeley

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We're funny (and managers), ask us anything: career, networking, mentorship

5–6 PM • Room: White River E

Name just about any kind of newroom, job, story or industry crisis and these powerhouse journalists have been there, done it and survived - stronger and better than ever! They'll share all their best tips for working through tough times and making it as a journalist, finding and telling the best stories, how to make your IRE membership work for you and more. We'll save lots of time at the end for questions and some lively networking before the opening reception.

Cindy Galli — MS Now, Kate Howard — Reveal from The Center for Investigative Reporting, Diana Fuentes — Investigative Reporters & Editors

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What your newsroom knows (but can't find)

5–6 PM • Room: White River D

Newsroom archives hold decades of reporting. They represent thousands of sources, events and institutional knowledge built over the years. And yet they're incredibly unwieldy and difficult to leverage. How many of you search your own newsroom's archives through Google? In this panel, we'll walk you through how we built Subline, an end-to-end system that extracts knowledge graphs from newsroom archives. We'll demonstrate how it supports smarter archive search, article link prediction, multi-step investigative queries, and better reader-facing recommendations.

Avery Wallace Louis — Stanford University, Hannah Woodworth — Stanford Univeristy, Lucy Zimmerman — Stanford University

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Google Trends for election coverage

5–6 PM • Room: White River G

Learn how to use Google Trends to track search interest in real-time and support election coverage. We'll show you how to watch for major spikes in searches, get national and regional-level data and use search insights to find inspiration for your next story. This session is sponsored by Google Trends. IRE retains control of content, including the topic and speaker selection, for all conference sessions.

Alejandra Arevalo Zuniga — Google

Welcome reception

6–7:15 PM • Room: Griffin Hall

Reconnect with longtime friends and make some new NICAR connections. The reception includes a ticket for a complimentary drink and light appetizers will be available. We hope to see you there!

NIghtCAR (game night) ✨

6–8 PM • Room: White River D

Join fellow NICAR attendees for an evening of games, puzzles, etc. IRE provides the board games, you provide the fun! Feel free to grab a snack and a beverage from the reception or from the hotel and join the fun.

Friday, March 6

Mentor program breakfast (invitation-only event)

7:45–8:45 AM • Room: Griffin Hall

If you signed up for the conference mentor program, come meet your match at this invitation-only breakfast.

Utilizing new police misconduct and employment databases

9–10 AM • Room: White River E

Learn about using new, groundbreaking databases to track police misconduct and employment histories: the Police Records Access Project in California, ACLU of West Virginia/Dragline's Police Accountability Dashboard, the New York Police Disciplinary Records database, and the National Police Index. This hands-on session will also briefly cover other related police data projects around the country. This session is good for those with some experience using spreadsheets. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Sam Stecklow — Invisible Institute, Lisa Pickoff-White — California Reporting Project, Maheen Khan — Invisible Institute, Kyle Vass — Dragline, Beryl Lipton — Democrat & Chronicle

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Tips to investigate influencers and live-streamers

9–10 AM • Room: White River D

This session centers around the tools used for three recent stories involving video analysis. The reporting subjects include a deep dive into political podcasters in the run-up to the 2024 U.S. Presidential Election and linking the advertisers propping up right-wing influencers. Through these case studies we will highlight tools to archive videos, inspect metadata, analyze transcripts, map guest networks, and detect text and objects in video. Come learn some new tools for your next investigation!

Leon Yin — Bloomberg News

Automating mass scraping with AI

9–10 AM • Room: 104

This session will explore tools to create scrapers and structured data from websites with the help of LLMs. Scraping data off the web is not new for journalists, but what about when the data is spread out across hundreds of websites in dozens of formats? Writing and maintaining fleets of scrapers may have previously required a team of data journalists, but new methods allow us to use LLMs to analyze the structure of a website and automatically generate a working scraper. This means we can pursue stories involving more ambitious data collection on deadline. In this session, we will demonstrate a package we built at the Tow Center for Digital Journalism called "Scraper Factory," which uses LLMs to write Python scrapers. We will discuss stories where we have used this approach and solicit input from the community on best practices and innovations with these new methods. This session is good for those who have a familiarity of the command line, basic scraping skills, and are wanting to work in Python. Laptops will be provided. You will need a GitHub account to participate.

C.J. Robinson — Tow Center at Columbia University, Dhrumil Mehta — Tow Center at Columbia University, Tory Lysik — Tow Center at Columbia University

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Using immigration data to tell stories in your community

9–10 AM • Room: 102

There's no shortage of data that can help you tell local stories on the sprawling immigration beat, but the data are often scattered, inconsistent and come with lots of caveats. This hands-on session will walk you through telling a data-driven story on asylum rates in your city or state, from gathering the data to analyzing it. We'll also give you an overview of other immigration data sources to help you tell stories on how policies out of Washington impact your community - from immigration enforcement to the court system. This session's instructors are fluent in both Python and R. Code in both languages will be provided and instructors will be able to assist attendees following along in either language. The class will be taught in whichever language the majority of attendees vote for at the start of the session!

Joe Yerardi — The Philadelphia Inquirer, Julia Ingram — CBS News

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Editing the machine: Fact-checking AI-assisted reporting in the newsroom

9–10 AM • Room: White River B

As AI tools move into daily reporting, the real challenge isn't keeping up with the hype, it's the editing. This session is focused on the real editorial challenges that come up when you're responsible for people, data, ethics, and deadlines all at once-and AI is ambient and often invisible. This isn't a heady conversation about the future of AI in journalism, ethics boards or tech tips. It's meant to focus on what's already changed and how that shows up in newsroom decision-making. The goal is to move beyond the abstract and talk about everyday editorial decisions. What feels different in copy review? In sourcing? In data analysis? Where do editors need to slow down, ask a different question, or reopen a framing that might have quietly solidified? This is about how editorial judgment evolves when AI is in the workflow.

Angeliki Kastanis — Associated Press, Jennifer LaFleur — UC Berkeley School of Journalism, Meghan Hoyer — The Washington Post

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How to HMDA: Finding the story in mortgage lending data

9–10 AM • Room: 205

Every year, the federal government collects and publishes information about millions of home mortgage loan applications across the country: The places they're coming from, the people submitting them and the financial institutions accepting - or denying - them. In this session, you'll learn: - What Home Mortgage Disclosure act data is, what it includes and why it's collected - How The Banner used HMDA data to identify a newly popular, poorly regulated loan product and report on a foreclosure crisis in Baltimore + other questions HMDA data can answer - The R code you need to answer those questions! Folks with an understanding of basics (filtering, sorting, grouping and joining) in R will get the most out of this session. Laptops will be provided.

Sahana Jayaraman — The Baltimore Banner

Five demos for finding things with A.I. outside of chatbots

9–10 AM • Room: White River G

The most exciting new A.I. tools don't involve chatbots. We all have big documents and datasets. Sometimes we think we know approximately what's inside - but we just need to find it. In this session, we'll show you five more technical ways that A.I. can be used to supercharge the investigative process. We will demo semantic search for text, spreadsheets and images; embedding and clustering; and identifying visual objects in media - all in tools you can use yourself to solve real journalistic problems, without having to endure ChatGPT's excessive use of em-dashes and its other limitations.

Dylan Freedman — The New York Times, Duy Nguyen — The New York Times, Jeremy Merrill — The Washington Post, Angela Eichhorst — CT Mirror

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How we cover local elections using Svelte and Datasette, and how you can do it too

9–10 AM • Room: 201

Adam Marton and Jerry Zremski demonstrate how they develop the Local News Network's signature online voter guides -- including the one they're working on now, which will cover every Maryland General Assembly primary this year. Using the combined power of Datasette and SvelteKit, the voter guide starts as a simple google spreadsheet before being transformed into a powerful dynamic website. Jerry will talk about the editorial efforts behind the voter guide and the resulting journalism and Adam will discuss the nuts and bolts of development (including code that attendees can use to build their own site).

Adam Marton — University of Maryland, Jerry Zremski — University of Maryland

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QGIS 1: Spatial analysis for beginners

9–10 AM • Room: 204

Learn to how to make your own maps using free, open-source software called QGIS. This class will teach you how to get started importing and displaying geographic data. Not all datasets need to be mapped, but some do! We'll go over how to find publicly available data, prepare it for mapping, and join together different datasets. This session is good for: Beginners looking to learn the basics of visualizing geographic data. Laptops will be provided.

Becky Dale — BBC News, Harriet Agerholm — BBC News

Google Sheets 1: Getting started with spreadsheets (repeat)

9–10 AM • Room: 202

In this introduction to spreadsheets, you'll begin analyzing data with Google Sheets, a simple but powerful tool. You'll learn how to enter data, navigate spreadsheets and conduct simple calculations like sum, average and median. This session is good for: Data beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Monica Cordero — Investigate Midwest

Managing investigators: Leading those born to challenge authority

9–11:15 AM • Room: 209

Being a news manager is already tough, but what if you supervise investigative journalists? They come with an extra layer of challenges because their very job (and likely their personality) makes them hyper-alert to authority figures. This course is designed to give you some tools and tactics to lead individuals and entire teams of investigators more effectively. Learn from three investigative managers from different media at different stages of their leadership careers. How did they launch into their roles, and what experience have they gained along the way? This course is for current investigative managers and anyone aspiring to step into such a position in the future. NEW AT NICAR26: We'll tailor portions of this course for people who may be navigating AI and also offer details on IRE's new Managers of Color cohort. We're also squeezing it into two hours of learning, then an hour-long management networking/meetup event. Oh... and it's free to attend (typically, an additional fee is required)! Topics will include: managing compassionately, hiring challenges, transitioning to management, forging partnerships, building relationships, handling resource cuts, organization/structure, tough decisions/conversations, in-house training/growth, delivering feedback, creating inclusive opportunities, and juggling responsibilities/projects/work.

Josh Hinkle — KXAN, Emma Carew Grovum — Kimbap Media, Justin Myers — Chicago Public Media

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Finding the story: Public health data

9–10 AM • Room: 203

The CDC's PLACES dataset provides small-area estimates of health outcomes, risk behaviors, statuses, and health-related social needs. These estimates are available at the county, place, census tract, and zip level across the United States, making PLACES a powerful tool for understanding and responding to local health trends. In this session, you will learn how to navigate the CDC's ArcGIS Online public gallery, search for and bookmark PLACES data layers, add those layers directly to an ArcGIS Online Map Viewer, and use basic visualization and filtering tools to uncover a local public health story from the data. This session is ideal for anyone new to ArcGIS Online who wants to start using spatial data to ask better questions, identify patterns, and tell more compelling public health stories. Laptops will be provided.

Networking for international journalists

9–10 AM • Room: White River I

Do you dread checking the box on job applications that ask if you will need visa sponsorship now or in the future? Does navigating the American immigration system seem like an insurmountable task? It's hard to break into the field in general, but even harder as an international student or journalist trying to land a long-term job in the US. This session can be a space to share experiences, offer some tips, ask questions, find support, or just have a dedicated space to vent and connect.

Paroma Soni — POLITICO

Give back, together: Community service project

9 AM–12:30 PM • Room: Griffin Hall

Join fellow conference attendees for a hands-on community service project that turns compassion into action. In this drop-in volunteer experience, participants will work together to create no-sew, tied fleece blankets for animals at IndyHumane, helping provide comfort to pets as they await their forever homes. In addition, attendees will write encouraging cards for patients at the Richard L. Roudebush VA Medical Center in Indianapolis, offering messages of gratitude, care and support to those who have served. No prior experience is needed, so just bring your willingness to help and connect. This is a meaningful opportunity to step away from sessions, collaborate with colleagues, and make a positive local impact during the conference.

Demo: The Gun Violence Data Hub

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 202

Learn about the Gun Violence Data Hub, an initiative from The Trace, and how to use the data to report deeper and better stories in your own community. The Data Hub provides resources for newsrooms to bolster their U.S. gun violence knowledge, as well as an open data library of contextualized and well-documented datasets. This session is good for those with some experience using spreadsheets. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Aaron Mendelson — The Trace, George LeVines — The Trace

Customizing ggplot for yourself or your organization

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 205

Imagine a version of ggplot that is customized to your organization's style guidelines, in which you no longer have to write the same theme styling or geom_text layers every time you make a new chart. We've done that at Pew Research Center by writing our own graphics package made up of functions that modify, combine and extend existing ggplot functions (wrappers), and we want to share what we learned! Attendees will leave the session knowing how to get much closer to publication-ready graphics without leaving R, in far fewer lines of code. For those who may want to go beyond streamlining their own personal ggplot use, we'll also go over why (or why not) a custom R graphics package could be the right solution for their organizations - and how to start building one if it is. Attendees should have some familiarity with R and RStudio. Laptops will be provided.

Kaitlyn Radde — Pew Research Center

Finding the story: Trade data

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 201

As trade and tariffs become an increasingly relevant issue, this session will demo a free (but very unintuitive) tool from the U.S. Census: USA Trade! USA Trade has comprehensive, district-level data (with lots of hidden gems) that can be useful for data journalists across beats, especially those relating to global economics, trade, tech, and foreign policy. This session will demonstrate how to use USA Trade and discuss some ways to understand and use the data in your reporting. This session is good for everyone interested in learning more about trade stats. No data experience is necessary! Attendees will need to bring their own laptops (preferably no tablets) for the training.

Paroma Soni — POLITICO

Accessibility basics

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River E

Come to this session for a crash course in some of the issues to consider when meeting basic accessibility requirements for digital news. Panelists will discuss topics including color accessibility, alt text, mouseless navigation, and more.

Stacy Kess — Equal Access Public Media, Emilia Ruzicka — Independent journalist, Patrick Garvin — Maritz Global Events

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Analyzing images and videos with AI

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River D

Tools like facial recognition, red-light/speed cameras and crowd-counting have long been the territory of locked-up, super-secret algorithms from private industry and government. But no longer! Learn how to use open-source tools like the Python library supervision and open-source models to unlock real-world analysis abilities. Automate analysis of almost everything - from satellite imagery to TikTok videos - and unlock levels of small-team investigation that were impossible just a few years ago. Learn how AI can sort through images and video to help you wrangle footage from protests and riots (NYT), analyze trends on TikTok (Washington Post), keep an eye on your local school board meetings (Hearst), measure the effects of congestion pricing (Bloomberg), and a hundred other tidbits for when the cameras might be rolling. With a little Python and a dash of foundational knowledge, this session will tackle downloading videos, building and evaluating transcripts, splitting scenes, categorizing images, and detecting/counting/tracking objects.

Jonathan Soma — Columbia University

Persuasion 401: The psychology of investigative reporting

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River G

This training provides a deep dive into the psychology of persuasion so that reporters can increase their odds in getting record custodians to cough up data, reluctant sources to talk, and editors to support their projects. Tips will be research-based and help attendees learn the power of the mind. Note: Use these strategies for good, not evil!

David Cuillier — Brechner FOI Project

How to find data

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River B

A conversation about how to find and vet credible data sources that you can use right away.

Greg Morton — The Baltimore Banner, Stephanie Lamm — Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Sean Mussenden — University of Maryland

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Tracking hidden money, influence and power across borders

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River I

From offshore accounts to complex layers of companies, this session will show you how to follow it across borders and back again, using public data available to any journalist. This session will show practical ways to trace hidden owners, foreign ties, and influence networks using public records and open data. Attendees will learn proven methods to follow the money, connect global disclosures, and turn complex data trails into clear, high-impact stories.

Anna Massoglia — MuckRock, Ezana Ćeman — Organized Crime and Corruption Reporting Project, Klil Eden — Organized Crime and Corruption Reporting Project

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Using Python to scrape basic websites

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 104

This session will show you how to use the Python programming language to scrape data from simple websites. This session is good for: People with some experience working with data. Experience with Python and/or HTML is a plus but not necessary. Laptops will be provided.

Allan James Vestal — The Baltimore Banner

QGIS 2: Analyzing geographic data

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 204

Build on your existing knowledge of QGIS and learn how to explore, manipulate and analyze geographic datasets to gain new insights. This session is good for: Those who attended the QGIS I workshop or already know the basics of visualizing geographic data in QGIS.

Becky Dale — BBC News, Harriet Agerholm — BBC News

Google Sheets 2: Formulas & sorting (repeat)

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 102

Much of Google Sheets' power comes in the form of formulas. In this class, you'll learn how to use them to analyze data with the eye of a journalist. Yes, math will be involved, but it's totally worth it! This class will show you how calculations like change, percent change, rates and ratios can beef up your reporting. This session is good for: Anyone who has taken Google Sheets 1 or has been introduced to spreadsheets. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Lucia Walinchus — NBC Owned Television Stations

Connect with skeptical and disengaged audiences ... with data!

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River G

Data journalists have a unique opportunity to reach skeptical audiences who would otherwise reject established scientific facts. Let's highlight some journalistic endeavors to persuade and engage skeptical communities through innovative ways of presenting and explaining data.

Eva Constantaras — Lighthouse Reports, Aaron Mendelson — The Trace, Max Siegelbaum — Documented, Ariana Beedie — Mirror Indy

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Using open-source tools to investigate public transit

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 205

Public transit systems offer a treasure trove of data that can reveal vital insights into accessibility, equity, and efficiency. Together, we'll learn how to harness the data that powers tools like Google Maps and explore how these datasets can be used to investigate service coverage, travel times, and on-time performance. Whether you're uncovering how well a city serves its residents or tracking disparities in service quality, this session will arm you with the skills to transform transit data into compelling stories. This session is good for those with some spreadsheets experience. Laptops will be provided.

Greg Morton — The Baltimore Banner

How to scrape an entire social media platform

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 104

There's an interesting "alt" social media platform called pilled.net, which is popular in the conspiracy theory community. It has an API that's straightforward to engineer, and it has only about 1 million posts. So it's possible to fairly easily create a scraper, then scrape and analyze the entire platform. The sessions will show how to reverse engineer a social media platform's APIs, how to implement a scraper in Python, how to use the scraper to collect all the data, and then a few high-level analyses that can be done on the data. This session is good for those with some working with Python. Laptops will be provided.

Brian Whitton — The Wall Street Journal, Jack Gillum — The Wall Street Journal

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Everything you never wanted to know about crypto: A primer for data investigations

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River D

This panel will cover the basics you need to understand about crypto to start covering it, including how it works, what is the blockchain, where to find data and where to find experts. We'll put a heavy emphasis on prediction markets, the Trump family's crypto businesses and finding local stories.

Caitlin Ostroff — The Wall Street Journal, Jeremy Merrill — The Washington Post, Sam Kessler — The Wall Street Journal

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Nonprofit data 101

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River I

There's a good nonprofit story waiting to be written on every reporting beat and in every coverage area, if you know where to look. This session will teach you how to navigate the world of nonprofit data and documents. To gain tax-exempt status, organizations like hospitals, charter schools, colleges and humane societies must agree to report annual information on their finances, compensation of key personnel, conflicts of interest and more. If you know how to cut through the accounting language to find what you're looking for, these annual filings - and other documents generated by a nonprofit - can answer questions big and small and add useful context to your reporting.

Andrea Suozzo — ProPublica, Ellis Simani — ProPublica

How we did it: Student-led investigations

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River B

Are you a student journalist who wishes they had a clearer roadmap for getting started with accountability journalism? Let's talk about open records laws, data analysis, tools and what's available to you, even if you're at a private institution. This session is great for total beginners or those looking for story ideas.

Haley Parsley — Capital News Service, Andrew Miller — Indiana Daily Student, Sana Muneer — Boston University, Matthew Wuschke — Boston University, Tabitha Hidalgo — University of North Texas

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Google Sheets 3: Filtering & pivot tables (repeat)

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 203

A look at the awesome power of pivot - and how to use it to analyze your dataset in minutes rather than hours. We'll work up to using a pivot table by first sorting and filtering a dataset, learning how to find story ideas along the way. This session is good for: Anyone familiar with formulas, sorting and filtering in a spreadsheet program. Laptops will be provided, or you can bring your own (no tablets). You will need a free Google account to participate.

Craig Lyons — Arnolt Center for Investigative Journalism

R 1: Intro to R and RStudio (repeat)

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 204

Jump into data analysis with R, the powerful open-source programming language. In this class we'll cover R fundamentals and learn our way around the RStudio interface for using R. This session is good for: People with a basic understanding of data analysis who are ready to go beyond spreadsheets. Laptops will be provided.

Maggie Mulvihill — Boston University

Manager meetup: Networking for investigative leaders

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 209

Leading investigative journalists can be extra challenging, so let us help! Socialize, forge partnerships or find a support group at this NICAR26 meetup! Swap best practices, laugh at lessons learned along your journey and find out more about IRE's upcoming management training initiatives! This networking event takes place directly after the always-popular, slightly shorter, FREE "Managing Investigators" master class. You don't have to attend the master class in order to stop by the meetup, though we welcome you to check it out! This networking session is for anyone managing (or aspiring to manage) investigators.

Josh Hinkle — KXAN, Emma Carew Grovum — Kimbap Media, Justin Myers — Chicago Public Media

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Finding the story: Data to decode deportation

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 102

In this session, we will walk through some stories published by The Minnesota Star Tribune during ICE's unprecedented immigration crackdown and share some tips, data and resources for preparing timely data analysis of federal deportation activities in your state. This session is good for beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Jeff Hargarten — Minnesota Star Tribune

Finding the story: Using DNS search for investigative journalism (repeat)

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 202

Every online interaction begins with a lookup in the Domain Name System (DNS), the backbone of the Internet. As a result, there are digital footprints left behind in the DNS. With the demise of Whois, investigative reporters are looking for new tools to uncover these footprints. Learn how to use DNSDB Scout, a tool to query DNSDB, a historical passive DNS database, to discover previously unknown online connections and gain new information to advance your ongoing and breaking news investigations. Basic knowledge of the Domain Name System (DNS) is helpful, but not required. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Daniel Schwalbe — DomainTools

Implementing accessibility

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 201

You've got the hang of why you should be doing basic accessibility, but do you know what to do when it's time to put it into practice? In this interactive, hands-on session, we'll teach you how to write alt text, then challenge you with photos, infographics and maps right in the session. Whether or not you've attended the panel, Accessibility Basics, this session will be fun and educational. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Stacy Kess — Equal Access Public Media, Emilia Ruzicka — Independent journalist, Patrick Garvin — Maritz Global Events

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Automating your data collection with dashboards and AI sponsored by Bright Data

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River E

With AI taking on a role in nearly everyone's lives, whether it's simple interactions through platforms they already use or fully built systems, it's time for you to level up your data collection practices with AI as well. In this session, we'll review traditional data collection and explore automation to create dashboards that let your readers and viewers explore topics.

Jennifer Burns — Bright Data, Caelyn Gonzalez — Bright Data

Lunch bunch

12:30–2:15 PM • Room: TBD

Make some new friends over lunch! Show up and we'll connect you with other folks who want to chat and network over the lunch break -- a great way to make a big conference feel smaller. Meet at the bottom of the escalators on Level 1.

IRE student chapter meetup

12:30–2:15 PM • Room: White River B

Are you a member of one of IRE's new student chapters? Interested in starting one on your campus? Or just want to find other students to hang with during lunch? Grab your lunch and bring it with you to our student chapter meetup! Members from IRE's student chapters will share ideas for getting organized and planning successful programming. We'll discuss what's been working, what hasn't, and any hurdles you're facing to getting started!

Teaching data journalism in the AI era

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River I

As journalists, we spend years learning how to navigate data of all kinds and keep our investigations on track. Now students can ask an LLM to write their code or summarize a dataset in seconds... and get something back that looks right. Or let generative AI drive their assumptions about data without doing enough reporting. So how do we actually teach these foundational skills? While there's no finished playbook for this yet (or even consensus within individual schools or journalism departments), this panel will work through classroom strategies that let you use AI tools without short-circuiting critical thinking. We'll also get into which concerns about AI are real problems and which are overblown, plus where it might genuinely help students learn. You'll walk away with things to try in your next class, whether it's a new course or a curricular refresh.

Alex Richards — Syracuse University, Matt Waite — University of Nebraska, Elisabeth Gawthrop — American Public Media, Rahul Bhargava — Northeastern University

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Skills as executable tipsheets - a new way to collaborate on data projects with AI agents

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 209

Anthropic released Skills in October - a new mechanism for adding capabilities to AI agent tools such as Claude Code. Skills have a wide range of applications in data reporting. A skill is a Markdown file that explains to the coding agent how to achieve a task. It might explain how to connect to a database, or provide preferred patterns for building front-end components, or how to obtain and process US Census data, or common mistakes to avoid when reporting on jobs report. NICAR already has a strong culture of tipsheets. A skill is just a tipsheet with an AI agent as its intended audience! This session is good for those with some familiarity with coding agent tools, such as Claude Code. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Simon Willison — Datasette

Scraping without programming

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 202

"Scraping" is a catch-all word for grabbing information off a web page and into your spreadsheet - whether the website wants you to or not. This session will introduce easy, hands-on methods for scraping data from a live webpage without having to learn any code. We will use the ImportHTML and ImportXML formulas in Google Sheets. Scraping beginners welcome! Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Samantha Sunne — Independent journalist

Clustering and mapping text data for journalism

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 104

Analysis of large text datasets can be difficult, and finding story ideas can be even harder, especially when you're not sure what you're looking for. This session teaches you to explore large sets of documents using semantic maps-visual clusters with similar documents grouped together in a two-dimensional chart. Users will learn how to convert text documents into embeddings, visualize them in two dimensions, and explore the data for insights by applying filters by keyword or time period. Applications include: parsing FOIA responses, tracking similar legislative language, or finding new areas of concern in school board comments. Participants will leave with the ability to map and cluster a sample of text data with provided code. This session is good for those with some Python experience. Laptops will be provided. You will need a GitHub account to participate.

C.J. Robinson — Tow Center at Columbia University, Dhrumil Mehta — Tow Center at Columbia University, Aishi Chandra — Columbia University

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From satellites to stories: Leveraging Google Earth Engine to analyze global environmental datasets for local reporting

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 201

Accessing openly published maps and models from the latest research has never been easier through platforms like Google Earth Engine (GEE), enabling journalists to expose systemic patterns of environmental harm at scale-including those not already captured in government statistics-while honing in on, based on data, the most salient case studies for detailed ground reporting. In this session, you will learn how to access the forest change dataset powering Global Forest Watch for free through GEE with just one line of code. You'll then quantify changes to forests in a local area and, most importantly, analyze this remotely sensed data together with detailed local data to illuminate impacts of environmental change on communities. This session is good for those with some experience working with geospatial data. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Carl Churchill — The Wall Street Journal

Investigating TikTok through data donations

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River G

The Post collaborated with 1,100 readers to create a unique dataset of TikTok watch histories -- which they used to investigate political content, the app's addictiveness, and how the algorithm favors certain kinds of content over others. They also published the first Map of TikTok that hasn't been published yet but will hopefully break the internet. We'll discuss this project from beginning to end, including participant recruitment, secure/private data processing, and technical hurdles to digging into a giant dataset.

Easy visualizations for your first data stories

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River B

Learn best practices for thinking about simple data visualizations to help tell your story - plus, a peek at some free tools!

Adrian D. Garcia — Financial Times Specialist, Elena Mejia — Bloomberg, Haohsiang Ko — Financial Times, Prinz Magtulis — Reuters

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Extracting data from PDFs using command-line and other advanced tools

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 205

This class seeks to help you free data stored in PDFs. Attendees will extract text from a computer-generated PDF using command-line tools, process image files with optical character recognition and set themselves up for working with PDFs in Python. The session will also cover how to assess a PDF to select the right tools to use to free its data. This session is good for: People with experience using a command-line interface and who deal with frustrating PDFs. Knowledge of Python or R is a plus but not required. Laptops will be provided.

Alex Garcia — Datasette

R 2: Data analysis and plotting (repeat)

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 204

We'll use the tidyverse packages dplyr and ggplot2, learning how to sort, filter, group, summarize, join, and visualize to identify trends in your data. If you want to combine SQL-like analysis and charting in a single pipeline, this session is for you. This session is good for: People who have worked with data operations in SQL or Excel and would like to do the same in R and have some experience working with RStudio. Laptops will be provided.

Karina Kumar — Austin American-Statesman

Networking: Journalists of color sponsored by ProPublica

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River D

Mix and mingle, meet friends old and new, and build your professional community in this fun and informal networking session. This session is for journalists of color.

Gemini for news

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 102

Level up your reporting with Gemini. This session focuses on key features like Deep Research for multi-step investigations, Custom Gems for scalable tasks, and Canvas for interactive drafting. Plus, discover how Gemini in Pinpoint enhances your research across large document sets.

Mago Torres — Google News Initiative

Using CAPTCHA-solving services to automate difficult web-scraping projects

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 203

This class will teach attendees how to use CAPTCHA-solving services to automate CAPTCHA solutions in web scraping. Attendees will learn how to efficiently identify and send required elements to the CAPTCHA-solving service and apply the unique codes received to navigate past CAPTCHAs encountered during web scraping. Special focus will be placed on tackling Google's reCAPTCHA v2, a commonly used CAPTCHA on the web, alongside strategies for overcoming challenges presented by more complex websites. The class will provide practical skills in CAPTCHA solving, equipping attendees with the knowledge to implement these solutions in their projects. This session is good for journalists with some Python experience. Laptops will be provided.

Ryan Little — ProPublica

Investigating the Epstein Files

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River E

Rob Barry — The Wall Street Journal, Jack Gillum — The Wall Street Journal, Jaclyn Jeffrey-Wilensky — The Wall Street Journal, Caitlin Ostroff — The Wall Street Journal, Brian Whitton — The Wall Street Journal

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Making better databases with Airtable

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 209

Airtable is a spreadsheet and database software with useful features to view, sort, group, and link records between tables. You'll see a few examples of how Airtable has been useful for the instructor's reporting (and why she almost never use Excel anymore!) and walk through a hands-on example. This session is good for: Anyone who has been frustrated at making multiple versions of the same spreadsheet, creating extra columns (or filters) and then repeatedly hiding and unhiding them, or jumping between multiple spreadsheets to bring together different information about the same record. This session is good for people with basic experience working with data. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets).

Amy Fan — The New York Times

Think spatially: Finding stories in geographic data with geopandas

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 205

Geographic data can do more than make pretty maps-it can help you find stories. In this hands-on session, you'll learn how to use Geopandas, a Python tool that lets you work with location data just like you work with spreadsheets. We'll focus on how to ask and answer reporting questions with geographic data: Which neighborhoods have the most potholes? Which schools are near industrial sites? Where do service gaps overlap? You'll learn how to combine and compare different datasets, look for patterns and boundaries, and measure what's happening where. We'll also look briefly at how to show your results on a map, but the main goal is to help you use location data for analysis-not just visualization. This session is good for people with experience working with Python. Laptops will be provided.

Janie Haseman — Hearst

Modern document processing with Natural PDF

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 104

Writing Python scripts to extract data from PDFs is always a nightmare - misshapen tables, arbitrary form formatting, tiny text or low-quality scanned texts. Your champion is here in the form of Natural PDF, a new Python library for wrangling data that's focused on usability and cramming in as many features as possible. Write your code just like you'd ask "real-language" questions: - "Find the bold text that ends with a colon and get the text to the right of it" - "Show me all pages that include diagrams" - "Ignore everything above the thick horizontal line" Natural PDF also comes bundled with all sorts of modern AI-based magic: - Categorize pages or entire PDFs by text or vision models - Use powerful layout analysis engines to recognize images, tables, headers, and paragraphs - Multilingual OCR powered by multiple engines + LLM-correcting integration Participants will leave with a solid understanding of how to extract data from difficult (and simple) PDFs using Python. This session is good for those with some experience working with Python. Laptops will be provided.

Jonathan Soma — Columbia University

Building web scrapers on the fly with ChatGPT and Claude

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 102

This session will focus on how to scrape data from public websites in breaking news and quick-turn situations. Use a tool like ChatGPT to help you quickly understand a website's structure and API calls to get data fast. This session is good for beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Charles Minshew — Atlanta Journal-Constitution

Cheatsheet: An investigative spreadsheet tool powered by A.I.

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River B

In this session, we will demo Cheatsheet, an internal tool developed at The New York Times that has helped in the reporting process for dozens of breaking news and investigative stories. Cheatsheet is a smart spreadsheet application that makes it quick and easy to analyze large datasets, document dumps and media collections at scale using A.I. systems. Cheatsheet gives reporters the ability to quickly find needles in large haystacks using recipes such as A.I. classification, translation, summarization, quote extraction and web search.

Dylan Freedman — The New York Times, Teresa Mondría Terol — The New York Times

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Advanced visualization and design in Datawrapper

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 203

Take your Datawrapper skills to the next level. This session will cover advanced features and techniques to make your visualizations more powerful, polished and interactive. Learn how to customize design themes and use advanced chart types to communicate complex data clearly and creatively. Some basic HTML knowledge is preferred, but not necessary. Laptops will be provided.

Jovi Dai — National Association of REALTORS®

How to do data-driven work in small communities

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River G

The Data-Driven Reporting Project was founded to support newsrooms who might otherwise lack the tools, training or capacity to do more technically-focused investigative reporting. These are often smaller newsrooms with fewer resources. This in-person panel discussion at NICAR will show examples of how journalists, who have received support from the Data-Driven Reporting Project, are navigating complex and data-driven stories on small and underserved communities. Speakers will share stories and how they problem-solved connecting with the people behind the data. Good for beginners.

Pam Dempsey — Northwestern University, Jill Blackman — Northwestern University, Aallyah Wright — Capital B News, Erica Peterson — Mountain State Spotlight, Chris Farone — Boston Institute for Nonprofit Journalism

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R 3: Gathering and cleaning data (repeat)

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 204

Learn how to import a wide variety of files in R including spreadsheets, files on the web and HTML tables, and transform the results into usable data. This session will also focus on how to clean and structure the data you've gathered in preparation for analysis using tidyverse packages. This session is good for: People who have some experience using R and the Tidyverse. Laptops will be provided.

Katherine Oung — Houston Chronicle

Behind the stories: 2025 Philip Meyer Winners

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River I

A data deep dive into the 2025 Philip Meyer Award winners. Hear from reporters on how they gathered, cleaned, analyzed and visualized the data behind some of the year's biggest stories.

Brant Houston — University of Illinois

Finding the story: Transportation data

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 201

This session will empower you to use data from the National Transportation Safety Board to investigative major railway accidents and overlooked safety recommendations. You'll gain practical skills to identify your own local stories on railway safety. Some spreadsheets experience will be useful for this session. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Cat Murphy — University of Maryland, Shradha Dinesh — McClatchy

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The art of the data FOIA

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 202

In this session, learn how to get exactly what you want from government agencies, in the format you want it in, and with all the fields you want. This hands-on session is great for beginners and anyone who wants to polish their FOIA skills. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

The art of networking - and why it's vital

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River D

What networking isn't: Collecting business cards and letting them gather dust in your desk drawer. What netowrking is: A way to build two-way relationships that turn into long-term connections. This workshop offers tips on creating the perfect elevator pitch to introduce yourself, finding the right people to meet and starting to build mutually beneficial conversations that translate into opportunities, collaborators and purposeful long-term connections.

Benét Wilson — IRE & NICAR

2025 Philip Meyer Awards presentation

5–5:15 PM • Room: White River E-F

Lightning Talks ⚡

5:15–6:30 PM • Room: White River E-F

Sometimes you don't need 45 minutes to explain a useful technique or interesting resource. Join your colleagues for a session of short (5-minute) talks about doing data journalism, web development and related topics.

Adam Rhodes — IRE & NICAR

NIghtCAR (game night) ✨

6:30–8:30 PM • Room: White River D

Join fellow NICAR attendees for an evening of games, puzzles, etc. IRE provides the board games, you provide the fun! Feel free to grab a snack and a beverage from the reception or from the hotel and join the fun.

Philip Meyer Awards reception

6:30–7:30 PM • Room: White River Foyer

Celebrate the Philip Meyer Award winners at a reception to honor them. Light appetizers and a drink ticket will be provided.

Saturday, March 7

The price of recovery: How to investigate opioid settlement spending

9–10 AM • Room: White River B

As states, counties, cities, and tribes begin spending more than $80 billion in opioid settlement funds, questions of transparency and accountability are increasingly urgent. In this session, five graduate students from West Virginia University's Reed School of Media will share how they used investigative and data reporting techniques to track settlement spending in their state - and how this approach can be replicated in your communities! Panelists will outline key strategies for data collection, open records requests, and newsroom partnerships, while reflecting on journalism's role in holding institutions accountable and amplifying community voices in responses to the opioid crisis.

Ty McClung — West Virginia University, Jessica Riley — West Virginia University, Drew Solt — West Virginia University, Claudi Di Lima — West Virginia University, Hannah Heiskell — West Virginia University

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Auditing AI algorithms for bias (and sometimes using AI tools to do so)

9–10 AM • Room: White River E

AI is everywhere and reporters are finding new ways to hold AI tools accountable, sometimes using AI to do so. This panel will discuss how journalists can identify bias in predictive and generative AI tools built by some of the largest technology companies, plus speakers will share which AI tools they use for investigations and research.

Hilke Schellmann — Independent journalist, Lucy Zimmerman — Stanford University, Sean Mussenden — University of Maryland, Daniel Trielli — University of Maryland

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How "Skills" solve the biggest pitfall in using AI for data analysis in Claude Code & OpenAI Codex

9–10 AM • Room: 104

We've all been there recently. Jazzed at experimenting with the latest AI/LLM tooling to help drive our data journalism. But there remains a particularly thorny issue when using AI tools for data analysis: they don't do things the same way twice, they can go rogue, and they're awful at math. They may be great at building web apps, but they can be very dangerous for doing actual data analysis. But the "skills" workflow has the potential to be a game-changer. They began in Claude Code and have now been adopted by Codex as well. What are "skills"...? They allow you to create specific, reproducible code chunks or even entire scripts that will then get executed. The file system is dead-simple: just markdown files and your code scripts. And from there, skills functions largely as an automation tool - it'll run what you've told it to run, when you tell it to, with certain variables provided by you or your colleagues. And it will ensure Claude or Codex gives you consistent, reproducible results every time. Learn what it's all about. This session is good for people with some coding experience. Laptops will be provided.

Aaron Kessler — Associated Press

Data team starter kit: How to build a data team from the ground up

9–10 AM • Room: White River D

How do you set a new data team up for success? How do you grow a data team while maintaining your team's identity and standards? This session will tackle best practices for establishing and maintaining standards on new and growing data teams. We'll cover automating onboarding, standardizing project structure with Datakit and setting up a robust fact-checking process.

Greg Morton — The Baltimore Banner, Allan James Vestal — The Baltimore Banner, Sahana Jayaraman — The Baltimore Banner

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Data collection at scale for countries where data is hidden

9–10 AM • Room: White River G

Learn about collecting data for countries where data is difficult to obtain, hidden, or behind wonky websites that don't give you access to actual insights. Find out how to obtain data and support reporting pipelines - also how to gather data that's more qualitative to supplement the numbers.

Tazbia Fatima — Hearst, Alexander Borodikhin — Mediazona, Inaara Gangji — UC Berkeley, Eunjee Wi — Arizona State University

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Beyond the big leagues: Data journalism in high school sports

9–10 AM • Room: 202

High school sports drive huge traffic but lack the data infrastructure of pro leagues. This demo will explore how journalists build databases and tell data-driven stories when official stats are incomplete or nonexistent. Panelists will share strategies for scraping and standardizing local sports data, creating searchable tools for communities, and making compelling visualizations. Attendees will learn how to find stories in oft-incomplete sports data and build resources that serve coaches, parents, and fans beyond a single season.

Rahul Deshpande — Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Josh Fine — HBO

Using regular expressions

9–10 AM • Room: 203

By the end of this class, this expression -- ^[A-Za-z0-9._-]+@[[A-Za-z0-9.-]+$ -- will make sense to you! You'll learn how to construct advanced searches on text data using regular expressions, a powerful pattern-matching syntax that can help you find needles in haystacks. This session is good for those with some basic experience working with data, and anyone who wants to learn to use regular expressions. Laptops will be provided.

Ethan Corey — Behind Bars Data Project

Google Sheets: Advanced pivot tables

9–10 AM • Room: 102

You've done a few pivot tables and are getting curious about what more you could do with them. What happens if you aggregate by more than one column? What are those "column" and "filter" boxes for? Come unlock the full potential of pivot tables in this intermediate spreadsheet class. This session is good for: People familiar with spreadsheets and aggregating data with pivot tables, or anyone who has taken Sheets 1-3. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Koby Levin — Outlier Media

Using LLMs to improve your archives

9–10 AM • Room: 205

Most newsroom archives contain years of institutional knowledge unread by most. This session shows how to unlock them to make your reporters more informed and to help onboard new journalists. Drawing on a university course where journalism students with little coding experience built "beat books" from local newspaper archives from Maryland's Eastern Shore, we'll walk participants through a reproducible pipeline using open and commercial LLMs. Laptops will be provided.

Derek Willis — University of Maryland, Clayton Ludwig — University of Maryland, Cat Murphy — University of Maryland

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Introduction to R

9 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 204

We'll introduce you to R, a free, powerful open-source programming language that will take your data reporting to the next level. By the end of this three-hour session, you will be able to read data from common file types into R, clean and explore it, create visualizations, and make your entire data workflow reproducible. We'll also talk about how to find help when you're stuck. Workshop prerequisites: This session will be most helpful if you're comfortable working with data and you're ready to take your skills to the next level. Preregistration is required and seating is limited. Laptops will be provided for the training.

Liz Lucas — University of Missouri, Mariia Novoselia — University of Missouri

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Media lawyer Q&A: Student edition

9–10 AM • Room: White River I

Maggie Mulvihill — Boston University, Eric Feder — Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press (RCFP), Kris Cundiff — Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press (RCFP)

Find public records and leaks: The new OCCRP Aleph Pro

9–10 AM • Room: 201

You've got a leak, a name, or a suspicious company - what's your next move? In a world of complex financial secrecy, uncovering the truth demands data power. Join this hands-on workshop to master the all-new OCCRP Aleph Pro, holding over four billion records of leaks, sanctions, corporate registries, and beyond. For years, Aleph has been the backbone of hundreds of investigations, and we have now evolved it to meet the challenges of modern reporting. Bring your laptop and learn to cross-reference targets, generate structured entities from raw text, and map hidden connections into visual networks. You will also learn how to secure access to protected leaks curated for journalists, activists, and researchers. It's time to power your next investigation using Aleph Pro. Please fill out this form by Wednesday, March 4th, to have an account created and access granted for OCCRP Aleph Pro. Because this will be a highly interactive session where you'll have the opportunity to create your own investigations and visual networks using Aleph Pro, prior account setup is strictly required. This session is good for beginners and anyone who wants to learn to use Aleph Pro.

Ezana Ćeman — Organized Crime and Corruption Reporting Project, Klil Eden — Organized Crime and Corruption Reporting Project

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Finding the story: Using data to report on statehouses

9–10 AM • Room: 209

Whenever journalists are told to follow the money, we know that always means having a strong grasp on the data that is used to advocate for bills and the backdrop of who may be funding what. Come learn how to dig into the data out there with some hands-on exercises. Laptops will be provided.

Marina Villeneuve — Hechinger Report

Elevate your graphics with Illustrator!

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 202

Illustrator is a great tool for creating beautiful, completely unique data viz and graphics - but the best part is it doesn't need to all be done from scratch. In this session, we will go over ways to begin making your chart using various online tools that most newsrooms already use (like Datawrapper, RawGraphs, Flourish, ggplot, etc.) but elevate its design with the magic of SVGs and vector graphics programs like Adobe Illustrator. We'll talk through color choices, fonts, accessibility, framing, and more - and give you tips and tricks to create stunning graphics that you can customize to your heart's delight. This session is good for beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Paroma Soni — POLITICO, Stephanie Stamm — The Wall Street Journal

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Using open-source intelligence (OSINT) in investigations

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River E

This session will show how journalists can begin incorporating open-source research methodologies in their investigations, with examples from real articles.

Tristan Lee — Decoherence Media, Jennefer Harper — Decoherence Media, Alison Killing — Financial Times, Gabriel Geiger — Lighthouse Reports

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Scraping dynamic websites with browser automation tools

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 201

Playwright is a next-generation browser automation tool that allows you to use Python or JavaScript to scrape almost any web page. It can assist in downloading pages of government documents, capturing tweets before they get deleted, or even just breaking past the cookie consent banner. Beyond the basics, it can also easily take screenshots, monitor and log network requests, and even fit right into your traditional BeautifulSoup scraping approach. We'll look at: - Installing Playwright - Accessing elements on the page - Interacting with web pages (clicking, navigating, filling out forms) - Taking screenshots - Sending pages to traditional scraping tools like BeautifulSoup - Common patterns including pagination and CAPTCHA breaking For those of you familiar with tackling similar problems using Selenium: Playwright is a similar tool with a better interface, better install/upgrade process, and ten times the usability. It might be time to upgrade! Participants should have a basic knowledge of Python and HTML, but we'll also cover how to breeze past those basics with AI assistance. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Jonathan Soma — Columbia University

Becoming acquainted with your city as a data reporter with no beat

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River D

Early-career, local data journalists might find themselves needing to quickly navigate the data ecosystem of a new place for the first time. In this session, panelists will share their tips and tricks for: - Learning what kinds of data are easily available in your new home - Building out a "beat" for yourself - Collaborating across multiple desks - working with a wide array of datasets

Sahana Jayaraman — The Baltimore Banner, Bianca Pallaro — The New York Times, Elliott Ramos — CBS News, Kara Newhouse — Howard Center for Investigative Journalism

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The winding paths of a data journalist

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 102

Data journalists have unique skills and experiences that are applicable to product design and management roles. Learn from panelists who have navigated unexpected journeys to find their niche in the data world. This panel is great for people who are curious about making a career shift, and hearing from professionals who have firsthand experience in making these transitions. Our panelists will share their strategies and lessons learned, offering valuable insights for those considering a similar career pivot.

Tejal Wakchoure — NBC, Arlene Martinez — Good Jobs First, Allan Lasser — MuckRock, Elizabeth Renter — NerdWallet

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Reporting on disappearing data about LGBTQ+ people

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River I

Reporters all over the country have scrambled to find and use quality data after the federal government deleted thousands of records about DEI, health, and the environment, to name a few. But as LGBTQ+ people are a notable target of the Trump Administration, it's not surprising that data about LGBTQ+ people has gone dark, been altered or is otherwise now more difficult to find. Come to this session to learn about what has happened to data about LGBTQ+ people, where to find it, and what happens when you need to be your own data architect.

Adam Rhodes — IRE & NICAR, Emilia Ruzicka — Independent journalist, Zak Cassel — WFYI

Deep dive: Navigating nonprofit data

10:15 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 209

More than half a million organizations - from your local humane society to some of the largest hospital chains in the nation - file annual public tax returns detailing revenue, expenses, staffing information, and more. In this hands-on session, we'll use spreadsheets to dig into filing data and answer questions about nonprofit organizations that you can apply to nearly any beat or coverage area. No coding experience is necessary, but we'll discuss ways to dig further into these datasets using code. You must bring your own laptop (no tablets) to participate.

Andrea Suozzo — ProPublica, Ellis Simani — ProPublica

Networking: Women in data

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River G

In this session, women, trans and non-binary folks in data journalism and investigative reporting will discuss the unique challenges they face, including the nuances of working in the field, issues of imposter syndrome and how to be our own advocates. Participants will have a safe space to ask questions, share experiences and network with one another.

Maggie Green — ABC News

First PMTiles Map: How to map massive datasets

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 104

Join Ben Welsh and Jon Schleuss to learn how to display a massive dataset on an interactive map using PMTiles and MapLibre. This one-hour, hands-on class will show you how to: Convert massive shapefiles to the compact PMTiles format using tippecanoe Display the tiles on an interactive map using MapLibre GL JS Create a data-driven style that colors features based on their attributes

Ben Welsh — Reuters, Jon Schleuss — NewsGuild

Big Local News tools, wares and resources

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River B

A lightning-round showcase of innovative newsroom tools and other resources that can help you collaborate on data journalism projects, harvest data and documents at scale, and track institutions for accountability reporting, from police agencies to state legislatures.

Ryan Pitts — Big Local News, Cheryl Phillips — Big Local News, Gerald Rich — Big Local News, Serdar Tumgoren — Big Local News, Rosie Cima — Big Local News

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From spreadsheet to map in 60 minutes

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 203

Have a spreadsheet with latitude and longitude coordinates and need to turn it into a map quickly? This hands-on QGIS session focuses on the practical workflow journalists use most: importing tabular data, creating a point layer, adding geographic context, and styling a clear thematic map ready for publication. We'll skip the broad GIS overview and dive straight into the essential steps so you leave with a publishable map and a repeatable workflow you can use in your reporting.

Charles Minshew — Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Jennifer LaFleur — UC Berkeley School of Journalism

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How to get a pile of documents processed for machine learning

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 205

Rob Wells — University of Maryland

Office Hours: one-on-ones with managers

10:15 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River Foyer

Looking for specific feedback on a cover letter or portfolio piece? Maybe you want to wordsmith a section of your resume or update your bio. Sign up for a 20-min one-on-one session with a manager or newsroom leader with expertise in data, editing, investigations, career pathways and more

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Immigration data and how to make sense of it

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River G

The Trump administration has drastically reshaped immigration enforcement. Newsrooms around the country are trying to make sense of what is happening to their communities. Join this panel to learn how reporters break down the most important immigration data sets and how that data can be used to tell both local and national stories.

Will Craft — The Guardian, Leon Yin — Bloomberg News, Tanvi Misra — Independent journalist, Elena Mejia — Bloomberg

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How to educate journalism students about AI and with AI

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River I

Artificial intelligence is here to stay, so it's important to have a plan in place to educate the next generation of journalists. This panel of journalists and educators will hold a town hall-style session to share strategies and ideas on effective ways to educate journalism students about AI. Attendees will learn about what has and hasn't worked, how to use and build tools and how to be ethical and accountable when using AI.

Hilke Schellmann — Independent journalist

Automating your workflows with Github Actions

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 202

There are a ton of routine data sets that we pull regularly to analyze. Crime, housing, construction. But what if you could do that while you sleep? Github Actions allows you to do just that. Participants should have a basic knowledge of Github. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Sean McMinn — POLITICO

Presents for your future self: Automated workflows for making charts and maps

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 104

When you're working on a project with shifting or updating data, there's nothing better you can do for yourself than to build your own little sprocket bot. In this workshop, learn how you can build that bot through command line tools (makefile, node.js, python) to automate tasks like mapmaking. Learn workflow tips for Illustrator, Photoshop, Blender, and more! Save time by setting up a file and forever more executing it via a push of the button. Folks with an understanding of command line tools will get the most out of this session. Laptops will be provided.

Dylan Moriarty — The Washington Post

Beyond the investigation: Managing stress, safety & mental wellness

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 102

NO RECORDING! Covering sensitive topics can take an emotional toll, including long working hours, emotional strain and personal sacrifices. A panel of journalists will share strategies that help attendees recognize early signs of stress, create grounding techniques and find healthy outlets outside of work to protect their mental health.

Disha Raychaudhuri — Reuters, Cate Charron — Indy Star, Lakeidra Chavis — The Marshall Project

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Data crowd competition: 40 ideas in 40 minutes

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River E

This session invites attendees to compete for prizes for offering the coolest, most unique public datasets that every journalist should request. Each person gets one minute to come up to the mic and explain their dataset. The idea will be entered into a list of the screen, and then at the end attendees vote for their favorite. The top three win fabulous IRE merchandise.

David Cuillier — Brechner FOI Project, Cierra Putman — WTHR, Samantha Sunne — Independent journalist

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Covering growing corporate power, even on deadline

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River D

As corporate influence and power grows, it grows increasingly important to document the broader impact of business leaders' actions. For instance, companies are fined billions of dollars each year for stealing workers' wages, degrading the environment, defrauding the government, cheating consumers, and other misconduct - using Violation Tracker, reporters can look up the behavior of companies across more than 450 federal, state, and local regulatory agencies. Many of those same companies also receive billions in taxpayer subsidies in the name of economic development - using Subsidy Tracker, reporters can explore those tax breaks and other giveaways. Taken together, these two databases can help a reporter find patterns and trends in the ways businesses operate, and explore the ways governments enable poor behavior by corporate leaders to continue.

Arlene Martinez — Good Jobs First

How to avoid a midterm meltdown: Tips for covering elections

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River B

This panel will show how journalists navigate covering elections with data and how to avoid common mistakes. Speakers will share tips and stories about reporting on election results, campaign finance, and voter turnout.

Phoebe Quinton — Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Ence Morse — The Washington Post, Derek Willis — University of Maryland, Alexandra Glorioso — Miami Herald

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Using Python for data analysis

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 203

Imagine rolling Excel and SQL into one tool that also allows you to track your code and share it: That's pandas in a nutshell. There's a lot more you can do with it, of course, but this will be a good start. We'll learn how to slice and dice our data and extract basic stats. Specifically, we'll cover loading the data, filtering, sorting and grouping data. This class is good for: People who are comfortable with Excel and are familiar with the basics of SQL and Python. We recommend that you attend a Python 101 session or have equivalent experience before coming to this class. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Caitlin Ostroff — The Wall Street Journal

Google Sheets: Importing & data prep

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 201

Don't give up if your data isn't presented in a neat spreadsheet. This session will teach you how to get data into a spreadsheet and prepare it for analysis. We will look at how to import text files, deal with data in a PDF, and get a table on a web page into a spreadsheet. This session is good for: Anyone comfortable working in Google Sheets. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Rosmery Izaguirre — POLITICO

Excel 2: Formulas & sorting (Mac lab)

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 205

Much of Excel's power comes in the form of formulas. In this class, you'll learn how to use them to analyze data with the eye of a journalist. Yes, math will be involved, but it's totally worth it! This class will show you how calculations like change, percent change, rates and ratios can beef up your reporting. This class will be taught on Mac computers. This session is good for: Anyone who is comfortable navigating Excel. Laptops will be provided.

Jessica Huseman — Votebeat

Lunch bunch

12:30–2:15 PM • Room: TBD

Make some new friends over lunch! Show up and we'll connect you with other folks who want to chat and network over the lunch break -- a great way to make a big conference feel smaller. Meet at the bottom of the escalators on Level 1.

Collaborating in an intergenerational workspace: let's get to yes

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River I

From Boomers to Alphas, there is currently a wider range of ages than ever trying to create extraordinary journalism side-by-side during ever-changing and unprecedented times. Technology has created levels of haves and have-nots, digital natives and cultural luddites. But at the end of the day, our teams are here to serve our audiences and our communities: together. Let's talk about ways we can collaborate and find common ground, even when it feels sticky or difficult. Participants will come away with a framework for collaborative decision-making and have the chance to roleplay in groups, trying different mock scenarios among peers.

Emma Carew Grovum — Kimbap Media, Will Lager — Independent journalist, Teresa Mondría Terol — The New York Times, Garry Pierre-Pierre — URL Media

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Fun with hypotheticals: Investigating your dubious data dilemmas in real time

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River E

From the people who dared to ask "How many rats are in the Rainforest Cafe?" at NICAR25 comes an interactive panel on approaching a data story with an investigative mindset - this year done in real time. Attendees are encouraged to submit their most ridiculous investigative questions ahead of and during the panel. As a group, we'll take a few of those questions and propose and refine a hypothesis, make a reporting plan, brainstorm records requests, and more. By the end of the session, participants will be equipped to craft an investigative data story from scratch - starting from even the most unexpected or whimsical question. Submit your ideas at https://tinyurl.com/hypotheticals26.

Adiel Kaplan — Tow-Knight Center for Journalism Futures, Veronica Penney — American Association for the Advancement of Science, Emily Zentner — The California Newsroom

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How to use AI responsibly

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River D

Journalists across the world are trying to determine how and when to use GenAI and other machine learning techniques for reporting. Panelists from a range of projects and newsrooms will discuss how they considered journalistic ethics while using AI. Attendees should leave with ideas on when to combine AI classification with manual review, what to disclose to audiences and other practical tips.

Lisa Pickoff-White — California Reporting Project, Sachita Nishal — Northwestern University, Dylan Freedman — The New York Times, Katey Rusch — UC Berkeley

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Using coding agents for data analysis

2:30–6 PM • Room: 104

Coding agents such as Claude Code and OpenAI Codex are mainly marketed at developers, but they're actually applicable to a much wider array of problems, including data analysis, data cleaning, web scraping and other tasks commonly faced by data journalists. In this session, you'll learn how to apply these tools to both simple and ambitious data reporting projects. Attendees will go away with a very powerful new tool for collecting, exploring, analyzing and presenting data. Laptops will be provided.

Simon Willison — Datasette

Building your first SvelteKit data app

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 205

SvelteKit is a user-friendly JavaScript framework that allows you to easily build and deploy web apps. Join us for a crash course in using SvelteKit to make a data-driven interactive. This session is great for those with frontend development knowledge. Laptops will be provided.

Tyler Machado — Independent journalist

Rubric-a-palooza

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 209

At this demo party, we'll discuss the Science of Teaching and Learning (SoTL) behind effective ways to give students feedback. Ideally, we'll learn tips and tricks from one another as well as from the literature and do a hands-on exercise using AI tools to help us write effective rubrics for our assignments.

Dhrumil Mehta — Tow Center at Columbia University, Aarushi Sahejpal — American University

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Scraping with Python

2:30–6 PM • Room: 202

In this workshop you'll learn how to investigate websites, evaluate scraping difficulty and use Python to scrape data not otherwise easily obtained with out-of-the-box tools. Among the examples you'll discuss is a project to scrape some difficult data out of the Florida Financial System. Preregistration is required and seating is limited. You must bring your own laptop (no tablets) to this training.

Alexandra Glorioso — Miami Herald, Aïcha Camara — McClatchy

Elections 2026: Uncovering influence operations in the U.S.

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River G

This panel will demonstrate how to use tools to investigate and track influence operations. Journalists will learn how to piece together opaque spending networks and uncover crucial details about operations through tax returns, Foreign Agents Registration Act (FARA) filings, digital ad data, corporate records, lobbying disclosures and other sources.

Anna Massoglia — MuckRock

Making public data actually public: Building tools to serve communities

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: White River B

Public records are technically "public," but that doesn't mean they're accessible. This panel features journalists who've taken hard-to-use government data and transformed it into searchable databases that serve their communities. Panelists will share case studies of look up tools for stories like city council redistricting, voter registration cancellation and more. We'll discuss how to navigate the technical and editorial decisions involved in cleaning and publishing messy government data, the reality of maintaining these tools long-term, and maintaining reader/user/data privacy.

Rahul Deshpande — Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Jennifer LaFleur — UC Berkeley School of Journalism, Cam Rodriguez — Independent journalist, Kevin Uhrmacher — ProPublica

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Custom dataviz with JavaScript 101

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 102

Interested in building data visualizations for the web? This session will introduce you to charts made with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, helping you understand how various components combine to create a complete visualization displayed in your browser by coding. This session is good for journalists who are new to HTML, CSS, and JavaScript. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Andrew Briz — POLITICO

Extracting data from PDFs using off-the-shelf tools

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 204

Join this class to learn how to liberate data trapped inside PDF files. This class will cover basic approaches for getting text out of PDF documents using powerful and freely available tools. Participants will be introduced to basic concepts and walked through tackling common challenges encountered with tricky PDF documents. This session is good for beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Maggie Mulvihill — Boston University

Spatial analysis in R: 101

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 203

Learn how to use spatial functions in R to level up your reporting. We'll explore tools for mapping, spatial joins, buffering and calculating distance - all using a single package. We'll center a story published by The Baltimore Banner on gun violence around schools to showcase an application of these functions and demonstrate best practices for basic geospatial analysis. This session is good for beginner and intermediate journalists with some familiarity with R. Laptops will be provided.

Ryan Little — ProPublica, Nick McMillan — ProPublica

Cracking the code: How to read local government budgets

2:30–3:30 PM • Room: 201

Local government budgets are plans - Hopes. Dreams. Needs. Priorities. They reflect power. They make promises. In this session, you'll learn how to read them and how to find the enterprise stories in the numbers. I'll also share takeaways from public finance professionals, including how they navigate the politics in the budgeting process. Lessons in this session apply to all local council, commission, school and authority budgets. This session is good for all levels of experience! Attendees will need to bring their own laptops (preferably no tablets) for the training.

AmyJo Brown — War Streets Media

How to categorize and clean text data with keywords, LLMs and embeddings: A roundtable

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River I

Our datasets are often not just numbers but free-text descriptions -- AI chatbot logs, TikTok transcripts or government contract purposes. Three-ish reporters discuss how to categorize this kind of text data with three very different techniques: ol' fashioned keywords, embeddings and LLMs. We'll discuss the trade-offs between cost, precision and recall and interpretability -- and of course tell some war stories. We'll also discuss how to come up with taxonomies that make sense and how to refine each technique.

Jeremy Merrill — The Washington Post, Brian Whitton — The Wall Street Journal, Andrea Suozzo — ProPublica

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Continuous improvement for reporters: Kaizen, preflight checklists and more

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 209

Let's talk about how we can make reviewing and improving our work and our recurring processes (both automated and manual) a core part of our workflow as reporters and editors. Panelists will discuss goal setting, review and improvement processes like the "plan act do check" cycle, the broader philosophy of growth through incremental change and documentation, and how systems used in manufacturing, aviation, tech and other industries can be adapted for reporters, especially when it comes to data and investigative work. This won't just be hypothetical: we'll discuss practical ways to turn these systems and philosophies into real-world workflows for both freelance and staff journalists.

Audrey Nielsen — MuckRock

"Vibe-coding" for experimentation and deadlines

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 204

Picture this: There's a data presentation format you've wanted to try for ages. Now, all of a sudden, you've got a perfect story to use it on - but it's running in two days. Your current systems can't make it happen. Third-party solutions don't fit your organization's look and feel. Starting from a blank code-editor window wouldn't get it done in time. What to do? This session will show how one journalist solved that problem, using agentic AI to describe an intended solution - and then iterate on functionality - all while guarding against AI hallucinations and other possible pitfalls. It's not a silver bullet, and it won't absolve you of having to vet logic and think critically. But when done right, it can be a massive force multiplier for someone who has the technical knowledge (but needs to meet a tight deadline). Folks with some coding knowledge will get the most out of this session. Laptops will be provided.

Allan James Vestal — The Baltimore Banner

To whom it may concern: An honest conversation with data team hiring managers

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River D

It's hard to know what to expect when interviewing for data journalism jobs. What are hiring managers looking for in your resume and cover letter? Are you expected to have a personal website, Github or social media presence? What should you come prepared to talk about during each stage of the interview process? Join us for a panel discussion on how different news organizations approach hiring. Be sure to bring your questions for the Q&A segment. Please note that this session will not be recorded.

Allie Kanik — Houston Chronicle, Meghan Hoyer — The Washington Post, Caroline Ghisolfi — Houston Chronicle, Will Craft — The Guardian, Hannah Fresques — ProPublica

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Turn the impossible into the doable: The random sample as a reporting tool

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River G

You want to know how often people get their wages garnished because of unpaid medical bills...but it would take years to comb through all those court cases. Or maybe you have a long list of people deemed fraudsters and want to know how many of them are still operating businesses...but it would be impractical to look up each one. It's time for a random sample. This session addresses how to use random sampling as a reporting tool, and how to write up your findings for a lay audience. We'll review questions like: How big of a sample do you need? How can you design your random sample so that certain populations or geographies (like rural areas) don't get ignored?

Rae Ellen Bichell — KFF Health News, Maia Rosenfeld — KFF Health News

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Custom dataviz with JavaScript 102

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 102

Interested in building data visualizations for the web? This session will continue the exploration in the 101 session of various charts made with HTML, CSS, and JavaScript, helping you understand how various components combine to create a complete visualization displayed in your browser by coding. This session is good for journalists with a bit of HTML and CSS experience, or participants who already attended "Custom dataviz with JavaScript 101". Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Andrew Williams — San Francisco Chronicle

Spatial analysis in R: 201

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 203

Take your spatial skills up a notch by learning to use image-based data derived from satellite observations. In this session, you'll discover how to navigate tricky filetypes like netCDF and TIF, all within the comfort of RStudio. Learn how to extract decades of real-time measurements from variables like ocean heat, temperature, land use, air pollution and more. By the end, you'll have the tools to join satellite measurements with traditional shapefiles. This session is good for journalists who are comfortable with the basics of R and Rstudio. Attending "Spatial analysis in R: 101" is recommended. Laptops will be provided.

Ryan Little — ProPublica, Nick McMillan — ProPublica

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ezesri: Mining public mapping data from Esri services

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 201

Local governments often publish spatial data to mapping giant Esri's platforms before posting it anywhere else. Learn how to use ezesri to discover more than 100,000 public data sets and extract them without code in journalist-friendly formats (csv, geoJSON, shapefile). The tool also features a Python package for power users. Some data experience will be useful for this session. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Matt Stiles — CNN

ICE enforcement violence needs a collaborative database!

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: White River B

Several newsrooms are collecting and reporting on instances of immigration enforcement violence. The Trace, The Marshall Project and The New York Times and others have at different points this year chronicled the violence of federal immigration agents across the U.S. But this moment calls for a comprehensive and collective effort -- not a competitive one. Join brains to plan and execute a national reporting database that will catalog as many instances of immigration enforcement violence as possible. Together we'll develop a plan, roles, and tooling to begin broad collaborative tracking of immigration agent violence. We'll name the project and draft a pitch document for news nerds to bring back to their senior managers for official organization-level adoption and sponsoring. Past projects like this have done nothing short of shape history -- COVID Tracking Project, anybody?? Come help make the most of these painful times.

George LeVines — The Trace

Excel 3: Filtering & pivot tables (Mac lab)

3:45–4:45 PM • Room: 205

A look at the awesome power of pivot - and how to use it to analyze your dataset in minutes rather than hours. We'll work up to using a pivot table by first sorting and filtering a dataset, learning how to find story ideas along the way. This class will be taught on Mac computers. This session is good for: Anyone familiar with formulas, sorting and filtering in Excel or another spreadsheet program. Laptops will be provided.

Tyler Dukes — McClatchy

Digging into death with CDC Wonder

5–6 PM • Room: 204

CDC Wonder contains a treasure trove of public health information based on death certificates across the country. This session will provide a quick start guide on using the website, pitfalls to avoid and ideas for stories you can take home -- like maternal mortality, overdose and cancer clusters. This session is good for beginners. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Destiny Herbers — Flatwater Free Press

Blockchain sleuthing 101

5–6 PM • Room: 205

This hands-on session will teach you how to explore blockchain data to find stories, from general transactions to betting markets like Polymarket. This session is good for beginners. Laptops will be provided.

Caitlin Ostroff — The Wall Street Journal, Sam Kessler — The Wall Street Journal

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Beyond ironclad: Fact-checking the data story

5–6 PM • Room: 102

Even with best practices, the most meticulous data reporter in the world can make mistakes. Catching these errors before publication can involve hours of tedious code review and debugging. Missing them can lead to corrections, retractions, or worse. This session will give attendees a hands-on demonstration of a data story fact-check. Participants will learn how to spot errors in data interpretation, how to catch and debug coding errors, and how to fix mistakes efficiently. We'll walk through an example data analysis containing errors based on real mistakes made by award-winning data journalists. (All examples will be fully anonymized!) Some sample errors: - Number parsing fails due to commas as the thousands separator - Invalid demographic analyses based on misinterpreted Census data - Dropped rows in joined datasets (inner joins considered harmful!) - Unweighted aggregations of percentages and other fractions This session is good for those with some coding experience. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Ethan Corey — Behind Bars Data Project

Uncovering wrongdoing with AI: Real-world methods and ethical boundaries

5–6 PM • Room: White River G

In this panel, journalists who have deployed AI on cross-border investigations share practical techniques, limits and guardrails for using LLMs and machine learning in data reporting. Case studies include: scraping court records and classifying gender-based violence cases in Eswatini using GPT-assisted workflows; using a hybrid of OCR, regular expressions and LLMs to classify and review tens of thousands of environmental impact documents in France; and using machine-learning tools to detect deforestation and forest fraud across Southeast Asia by building on existing scientific research. Sharing reproducible workflows, panellists will show how to combine human judgment and feedback with machine assistance for document processing, pattern detection, classification and verification. The discussion will focus on human-in-the-loop systems, responsible disclosure of AI-assisted work and strategies for managing large document sets without compromising editorial credibility and scepticism. Attendees will leave with concrete methods for turning messy, unstructured data into searchable investigative resources, practical verification checklists and guidance on how to document and explain AI-assisted reporting to editors and audiences.

Sotirios Sideris — Nieman Foundation for Journalism at Harvard University, Eva Constantaras — Lighthouse Reports, Sanjin Ibrahimovic — MuckRock, Jonathan Soma — Columbia University

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Code Buddies: Get help on your data project

5–6 PM • Room: White River D

Need help on a data project? Having trouble figuring out how to use that cool tool you learned about in another session? Just want to network with some other news nerds? Stop by this session and get one-on-one help from experienced data journalists who would be delighted to help you solve your problems.

Holly Hacker — KFF Health News, Jovi Dai — National Association of REALTORS®

Scraping without programming (repeat)

5–6 PM • Room: 201

Yes, you can scrape data without using code -- in fact, all you need is Google Sheets! We'll be using Excel-type formulas (don't worry if you don't know what those are, either) to make simple scrapers that automatically pull data into Google Sheets. It's the best way to get around clunky websites and unhelpful PIOs! This session is good for: Beginners who want to start using data for their stories. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training.

Samantha Sunne — Independent journalist

The Data Journalism Podcast LIVE! with ProPublica

5–6 PM • Room: White River E

Scott Klein and Simon Rogers of the Data Journalism Podcast sit down with the team behind ProPublica's Meyer Award-winning series, "Life of a Mother." Reporter Andrea Suozzo and Deputy Data Editor Hannah Fresques go behind-the-scenes on their investigation into preventable deaths after the Supreme Court overturned Roe v. Wade. Plus, we'll chat about what it's like to work on the data team at ProPublica - which is currently hiring!

Scott Klein, Simon Rogers — Google, Andrea Suozzo — ProPublica, Hannah Fresques — ProPublica

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Mastering NotebookLM for journalists

5–6 PM • Room: 209

Transform your reporting workflow with NotebookLM, your personal AI research assistant. We will cover how to instantly synthesize complex beats, generate inline citations, and explore features like audio overviews, mind maps, and data extraction-all while keeping your materials organized and searchable.

Mago Torres — Google News Initiative

Spatial analysis in R: 301

5–6 PM • Room: 203

Data that lacks a shared column for direct joins can often still be connected through maps. But common geographies like census tracts and precincts rarely align perfectly. Despite these challenges, it's still possible to estimate how votes shifted across neighborhoods or calculate statistical relationships using Census data. This process is called interpolation - learn how to translate data from one map to another and bridge geographic gaps in their data analysis. This session is good for journalists who are comfortable with the basics of R and Rstudio. Attending "Spatial analysis in R: 201" is recommended. Laptops will be provided.

Ryan Little — ProPublica, Nick McMillan — ProPublica

A view from both sides: 5 practical strategies for successful public records requests

5–6 PM • Room: White River B

Employing a smart strategy from the outset can make all the difference between progress and pushback when it comes to accessing public records. This session offers insights from both the PIO and journalist perspectives to help you shape your requests to be as successful as possible and know where to turn when facing delays or denials.

Kris Cundiff — Reporters Committee for Freedom of the Press (RCFP), Casey Smith — Indiana Capital Chronicle, Luke Britt — Marion County Superior Courts

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Building blocks of a better team

5–6 PM • Room: White River I

Is your team clicking together like a perfectly built structure or clunking along like mismatched pieces? Strong collaboration and communication are the foundation of any high-performing team, and in this interactive session, you'll discover how to strengthen both through the power of play. Using building blocks as both metaphor and hands-on tool, we'll explore what it takes to build trust, align around shared goals and adapt to change. You'll gain fresh insights into team dynamics, leadership styles and the invisible structures that support effective teamwork. Come ready to build, reflect and leave with practical strategies for assembling a more connected, resilient team: one brick at a time.

Tara Puckey — Radio Television Digital News Association

Sunday, March 8

Use our quiz to focus on policy, not politics, in 2026

9–10 AM • Room: White River B

Help your audience prioritize public policy over political party or personality in the 2026 elections with QuizTheVote. It will transform your existing candidate questionnaires into an interactive quiz in about an hour. We'll talk about how to prepare for and implement QuizTheVote, an open source resource built on Google sheets with no coding required.

Evan Wyloge — Independent journalist, sandra fish — QuizTheVote

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Stadium pulse: Building sports data visualizations on deadline

9–10 AM • Room: 205

Want to create compelling sports graphics fast? In this hands-on class, you'll build a "How's your favorite college basketball team doing?" visualization using March Madness data. We'll use Python and Jupyter notebooks to pull live data from an API, then create charts in Datawrapper. You'll learn the workflow for going from raw data to published graphic quickly: automating data collection, choosing which stats tell the story, and designing for both casual fans and stats enthusiasts. An understanding of basics in Python is helpful, but not required, for this session. Laptops will be provided.

Rahul Deshpande — Atlanta Journal-Constitution, Nick Devlin — ESPN

Google Sheets: Advanced pivot tables (repeat)

9–10 AM • Room: 201

You've done a few pivot tables and are getting curious about what more you could do with them. What happens if you aggregate by more than one column? What are those "column" and "filter" boxes for? Come unlock the full potential of pivot tables in this intermediate spreadsheet class. This session is good for: People familiar with spreadsheets and aggregating data with pivot tables, or anyone who has taken Sheets 1-3. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Catherine Allen — POLITICO

From vibes to scores: Build your own AI benchmark

9 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 104

You've built some sort of AI workflow - maybe a copy editor, idea generator, automated podcast, research assistant or tip pipeline - but how do you know how well it really works? And how do you know when it stops working? In this session participants will learn how to define "good enough" for an AI use case, implement both code-based and LLM-as-judge scorers, build a small test representative test set, and run evaluations. We'll be using Pydantic AI (Python) with the Braintrust platform, but concepts are perfectly portable to no-code tools or other evaluation toolkits. Participants should have a basic understanding of Python and have at least basic experience with AI use cases.

Jonathan Soma — Columbia University

NICAR-L hackathon 🤠

9–10 AM • Room: 202

The NICAR-L listserv has long been a source of inspiration and knowledge-sharing for data journalists around the world. But tapping into the decades of wisdom contained in its archives can be difficult with existing tools. Let's build something better! This session is good for people who get excited about cleaning dirty, inconsistently formatted data and building user-friendly tools. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) to participate in this class.

Cody Winchester — Investigative Reporters & Editors

AI tools journalists can use ethically

9–10 AM • Room: White River D

Artificial intelligence is reshaping how media-related professionals work, make decisions, and tell stories. From content creation and audience analysis to workflow automation and risk management, AI is no longer theoretical- it is embedded in daily practice.This session focuses on how media professionals are using AI tools responsibly. Participants will explore real-world applications, understand limitations and risks, and discuss how to integrate AI without sacrificing clarity, credibility, or values.

Benét Wilson — IRE & NICAR

Introduction to using satellite data for investigations

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 205

Satellite imagery can be a potential game-changer for investigative journalists - if you know how to access, choose, and analyze the image for little to no cost. In this hands-on workshop, a journalist with deep knowledge of satellite providers will share insider tips on how to acquire medium and even high-resolution images from commercial and public sources, as well as how to filter and use these resources to give investigations into topics like the scars of war or environmental disasters much greater reach. This session is good for beginners. Laptops will be provided.

Laura Kurtzberg — Investigative Reporters & Editors

Google Sheets: Importing & data prep (repeat)

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 201

Don't give up if your data isn't presented in a neat spreadsheet. This session will teach you how to get data into a spreadsheet and prepare it for analysis. We will look at how to import text files, deal with data in a PDF, and get a table on a web page into a spreadsheet. This session is good for: Anyone comfortable working in Google Sheets. Attendees will need to bring their own laptop (no tablets) for the training and will need a free Google account to participate.

Scott Pham — CBS News

Navigating federal campaign finance data

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: 202

This class will focus on using the FEC's web tools to access data. It will feature a hands-on demonstration of accessing reports as soon as they are filed. Participants will learn what is included in the reports, how to interpret entries, and potential pitfalls. The presenter will share a user-friendly spreadsheet template for viewing downloaded report data and walk participants through a simple recipe for creating compelling stories using campaign finance data. This session is good for everyone. Laptops will be provided.

Brendan Glavin — OpenSecrets

Data-driven stories ideas for students

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River B

Data-driven investigations don't have to be long projects. In this panel, journalism educators will break down student data stories you can replicate in your own classroom or community. We'll cover the data, the process and what can go wrong.

Gerry Lanosga — Indiana University, Diana Fuentes — Investigative Reporters & Editors, Craig Lyons — Arnolt Center for Investigative Journalism

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Quick-hit investigations

10:15–11:15 AM • Room: White River D

Learn strategies, story ideas, resources and tips for watchdog stories on a variety of beats. You'll get tips on how to produce meaty enterprise stories that take days or weeks rather than months.

Francisco Vara-Orta — Investigative Reporters & Editors, Adam Rhodes — IRE & NICAR

Taking it all home

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River B

You've picked up some new skills, filled your brain with inspiration and your notebook with ideas, but now what? We'll give you some tips on how to take advantage of what you've learned, avoid letting your skills get rusty and even continue learning when you get back to your job. Bring your questions, too! We'll have lots of time for that.

Liz Lucas — University of Missouri, Leah Becerra — Reynolds Journalism Institute, Laine Cibulskis — University of Missouri

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Introduction to the command line (OSX) (repeat)

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 205

Too often in data journalism we forget about the basics. And it doesn't get as basic as the command line. Even knowing a little will make your job easier. We will run through some simple commands, dive into working with spreadsheets and show you some handy tools he frequently uses at work. This session is good for: People who feel intimidated by the command line on their computer, but want to explore the power of command line tools. Laptops will be provided.

Brent Jones — NPR

Today's News for Tomorrow Q&A

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: White River D

Laura Moscoso — Investigative Reporters & Editors

Kick more ass with a Python class

11:30 AM–12:30 PM • Room: 201

Tired of chasing global variables through a bajillion lines of linear code? Piling up dozens of functions that never seem to quite cohere into an efficient workflow? There's a better way! Discover how to model your data with custom Python classes, creating reusable blueprints that make your code easier to read and harder to break. This session is good for folks who are comfortable writing basic Python scripts, including custom functions, but are new to object-oriented programming.